

STAGES OF COMPOSITION IN CHARLOTTE BRONTË'S FAIR-COPY MANUSCRIPT OF *SHIRLEY*

by

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ON September 8, 1849, James Taylor traveled from London to Haworth, Yorkshire, to collect the manuscript of Charlotte Brontë's novel *Shirley* for publication.¹ His firm, Smith, Elder and Co., had been awaiting the completion of the book for nearly a year. Readers both in England and abroad were eager to read the next work by Currer Bell, whose first published novel, *Jane Eyre*, had attracted so much notice. Before that, the previously unknown writer had co-written and published only an obscure collection of poetry with Acton and Ellis Bell that few had read. The public continued to speculate about the identity of this new author, who had written with such power and originality.

Composed in three physically distinct volumes for publication as a three-volume novel, the fair-copy manuscript of *Shirley* consists of high-grade writing paper—a mixture of wove and laid folded half-sheets—copied out in a clear, legible hand with a steel-tipped dip pen. Although the first two volumes of the manuscript are each made up of about 140 bifolia or approximately 280 leaves, the third volume is noticeably longer, composed of about 160 bifolia or 320 leaves. Examining these, one finds that the novel's text has been carefully written

1. The summary description conveyed at the outset of this essay draws on my bibliographical findings, described in detail later in this work. The dates are from correspondence collected in Margaret Smith's invaluable edition, *The Letters of Charlotte Brontë* (Oxford: Clarendon Press, 2000). For more on Taylor's invitation to Haworth, see *Letters*, 2:247. The research presented in this essay was made possible by a 2019 research award from the Willison Foundation Charitable Trust as well as a 2015 award from the Friends of Princeton University Library. I am grateful to Karen Chase, Jerome McGann, and Michael F. Suarez, S.J. for supporting those projects. A number of other colleagues greatly aided this work: Ann Dinsdale and Sarah Laycock at the Brontë Parsonage Museum provided not only access to rare and fragile materials, some of which were on display, but also expert guidance on their respective collections. Alexandra Ault, Karen Limper-Herz, Alexander Lock, and Laura Walker provided key assistance at the British Library. I am also grateful to Tim Dolin and David Vander Meulen, who both provided feedback toward the final stage of publishing this article. I am most indebted, however, to Terry Belanger, for reading this essay in its own various stages of composition during what turned out to be an unprecedented global pandemic. His bibliographical expertise, learned observations, and helpful suggestions improved this work at every turn. Finally, my own bibliographical research would not have been possible without his support and the early training that I received at Rare Book School. This work is dedicated to him.

out onto the recto of each leaf. (Only two leaves contain any content from the novel on their versos.) The upper right-hand corner of each leaf bears numbering in brown ink. At the beginning of the manuscript, the sequence appears to be regular enough. But starting in the second volume, the brown-ink numbers have been crossed out and replaced by a new series written in red ink that continues to the end of the third volume.

The manuscript's widely spaced lines provide ample room for alterations to its text. Although some leaves bear no revisions at all, most reflect at least some kind of change, whether the crossing-out of a sentence, the re-wording of a phrase, or the insertion of new writing in the author's clear hand. More remarkable though are other, more structural changes: a number of the manuscript's leaves exhibit large excisions—conspicuous gaps where portions of paper have been cut out with a blade. Some leaves are two-thirds of their original size, while others are less than half the height of other full leaves in the manuscript. One leaf has been sliced down to a small fragment containing just a few lines.

These gaping excisions appear to have been made with a pen knife. The edges where the unwanted parts have been excised are jagged—not the smooth continuous cuts made by scissors. It is likely that some, but not all, of the leaves bearing excisions were still conjugate, over the fold, with their companion leaves, when Brontë gave the manuscript to Taylor on September 8. In addition, some of the manuscript's quires, or groupings of nested bifolia, would likely have appeared to have been opened or sliced along their conjugate folds and then rearranged.² And some singleton leaves would have been inserted in various places.³

Upon Taylor's return to London, the fair-copy manuscript was probably reviewed by Brontë's publisher, George Smith, before being delivered to the printing house of Stewart and Murray, where it served as the printer's copy. There, the remaining folds of the manuscript's gatherings would have been opened with a knife or paper cutter, dismantling the manuscript's nested bifolia into individual leaves, and enabling their circulation in small batches among the

2. I discuss the manuscript's quire structure, as well as the sale of stationery in quires, in more detail below. There are instances where entire leaves were fully excised from the manuscript volumes, which would have necessitated splitting the manuscript's bifolia. For example, a leaf occurring in volume 2, which would have been numbered in pencil and brown ink as 374, is missing from Brontë's brown-ink numbering sequence in volume 2. It was removed as part of a revision to "Mr. Donne's Exodus" that entailed partial excisions to neighboring leaves 373 and 375 (BM ff. 94 and 95). The excisions and removal of the leaf, in this instance, pertain to a conversation in which the novel's heroines, Caroline Helstone and Shirley Keeldar, are discussing Robert Moore's guarded interest in Caroline. The extracted leaf, which almost certainly contained Shirley's outspoken thoughts on the matter ("In what way does it pique you?"), was removed by Brontë as part of the third state of the manuscript's composition—before the "C" stage of red ink numbering, a process also described in more detail below.

3. This aspect of the manuscript's composition, described in more detail below, is evident in the occasional insertion of odd numbers of leaves, given that the manuscript was in large part composed on bifolia.

compositors.⁴ In the printing house, each chapter of the manuscript was divided among the men, who would set their particular portion into type. Wilson began work on leaves one through three, his name appearing in pencil on the first recto of the batch. The name of another compositor, Courtney, appears at the head of the first full paragraph on the recto of the fourth leaf; he started setting the next few pages. Ross began work at the paragraph beginning on the middle of the seventh leaf, and Walter Beck (signed as "Walter") took the first full paragraph beginning on the tenth leaf. Robertson started with the thirteenth leaf—Allen, with the sixteenth leaf. Bicknell began with the nineteenth leaf and set the end of the chapter. And so the crew of compositors worked, collectively setting each handwritten chapter into type. The dust and grime from the sorts of lead type dirtied their hands, which sullied the fine linen paper of the manuscript with their fingerprints.

Within a matter of days, Charlotte Brontë received by mail the first proof sheets of her novel, along with suggested revisions from James Taylor and W. S. Williams, her readers at Smith, Elder.⁵ By September 17, she had marked up and returned the first batch of proof sheets for review by her publishers, who would then have sent the corrected sheets to the printing house.⁶ As part of this multi-stage process, Brontë agreed, at the suggestion of her publisher, to rewrite in English an essay that had appeared in French in the third volume of the manuscript; for this purpose, she asked for the return of the requisite portion. Her editors received and approved the new leaves of the manuscript⁷ and the proofs passed quickly back and forth between Haworth and London. A set was sent to New York to Harper & Brothers, which had paid George Smith £50 for the "first sheets of Currer Bell's new work" on September 20.⁸ The novel

4. The fair-copy manuscripts for *Jane Eyre* and *Villette* also served as printer's copy. As with the manuscript for *Shirley*, both were divided among the compositors, with sections of each chapter distributed to various typesetters. This procedure conformed with the general practices summarized by the printer William Savage, who notes: "Copy is generally given out to the compositor in regular portions . . . if in manuscript, a chapter, or section, as it may be; for the compositor has never the whole volume in his hands at once, excepting it be bound and not allowed to be cut up, or taken to pieces." See *A Dictionary of the Art of Printing* (London: Longman, Brown, Green, and Longman, 1841), 187. The printer Caleb Stower advises: "With manuscript copy it will be better to take one from the other in such a manner as not in the smallest degree to delay the imposition, or block up the letter; that is, that no compositor may retain the making up too long by holding too large a taking of copy." See *The Compositor's and Pressman's Guide to the Art of Printing* (London: B. Crosby and Co., 1808), 93.

5. Brontë had received the proofs by at least September 13; she wrote to W. S. Williams that day, questioning him on a matter "censured" by Taylor in the proofs returned to her. See *Letters*, 2:251.

6. *Letters*, 2:255.

7. *Letters*, 2:266.

8. This entry, which is not listed in Christopher Feeney's *Index to the Archives of Harper and Brothers, 1817–1914*, has been documented in detail by Eleanor Houghton in her chapter "Charlotte Brontë's Moccasins: The Wild West Brought Home," in *Charlotte Brontë, Embodiment and the Material World*, ed. Justine Pizzo and Eleanor Houghton (Cham, Switzerland: Palgrave Macmillan, 2020), 179. See Harper and Brothers, "Contract Book 1846–1898," 19, Reel 1/58, in *Harper and Brothers Archives—Microfilm*, Film no: 1266 (Cambridge: Chadwyck Healey).

was published in London on October 26 and later in New York on November 22.⁹ The proofs that Harper & Brothers received, however, did not reflect all of Brontë's final corrections for the first London edition.¹⁰ Harper & Brothers would silently correct their own text—either from updated corrected proofs or from a copy of the London edition.

Today, the manuscript of *Shirley* is housed at the British Library (BL), where it is shelved alongside the fair-copy manuscripts of *Jane Eyre* and *Villette*, as well as with manuscripts written by Robert Browning, Elizabeth Barrett Browning, and William Makepeace Thackeray—volumes donated to the library as part of the George Smith Memorial Bequest, which was initially made in 1914 upon the death of Elizabeth Smith, George Smith's widow. In 1933, the Smith children

9. For the London publication date, see *Letters*, 2:270. The earliest American advertisement for *Shirley* appears in the November 20, 1849, issue of the *Evening Post* (NY), which announced the novel's publication next Thursday morning. The *Newark Daily Advertiser* (NJ) reported receiving a copy of the book on November 22, 1849. Thanks to Vincent Golden for his assistance in locating these early ads.

10. When I began comparing copies of the first American edition with the manuscript and first London edition in the autumn of 2020, I discovered a series of variants in the earliest state of the last chapter of the first American edition that are reflected in the fair-copy MS, but not in the first London edition, as printed by Smith, Elder. My curiosity had been spurred by an observation made by Walter E. Smith, who noted in *The Brontë Sisters: A Bibliographical Catalogue* (Los Angeles: Heritage Book Shop, 1991) the presence of additional text on p. 206 of "some copies" of the first American edition in wrappers, published by Harper & Brothers (HB) in 1849, that was not present in any of the other editions he had seen: "You may meet these two again, reader, one day, or you may not; none but the presumptuous promise for the future: we know not what a day or an hour may bring forth" (Smith, 125). Smith did not trace this variant to the MS; but when I did, I found numerous other instances that clearly show that the English proofs initially used to compose the first American edition did not reflect Brontë's final text for the first London edition, but rather an earlier set of proofs that retained language from the MS and that were later altered or removed as part of subsequent proof-stage revisions. For example, on p. 203 in the second column of the first HB edition, the text reads: "a rose-tree, transplanted from the Hollow, which bloomed"—language appearing in the MS (BM f. 311); the Smith, Elder (SE) edition reads: "a rose-tree, which bloomed" (p. 306). Page 206 of the HB edition reads "stone or brick and ashes," as with the MS (BM f. 322), while the SE edition reads "stone and brick and ashes" (p. 316). Some instances include early text entirely removed from Smith Elder's edition of the novel. For example, the following text appears on BM f. 306 of the MS and in column two on p. 202 of the HB edition, but not in the SE edition: "I don't know whether I have duly disposed of all minor characters; I fear not; but if any friend wishes to know more, a note addressed to Mr. Currer Bell, Haylane Cottage, Hay, near Millcote, may be expected to meet with prompt attention. I confess this promise seems given in rather equivocal terms—no matter: the experiment, if approved, might be tried." A full list of variants from the first state of the N gathering of the HB edition will appear in a forthcoming critical edition of *Shirley* that I am co-editing with Tim Dolin for Cambridge University Press. These variants provide valuable additional insight into the texts of the proofs, which are no longer extant. I also located variants at the end of the first printing of the HB edition of *Villette* that correlate with the surviving proofs for *Villette* located in Sterling Library, University of London.

relinquished their remaining life-interest in the manuscripts, donating them to the national institution.¹¹

The manuscript volumes are bound in three-quarter leather bindings that Charlotte Brontë never saw. The manuscript's individual leaves are mounted on paper guards that she never touched, and some of the leaves have been repaired with paper made more than a century after her death. New leaves have been bound into the volumes, too, to replace ones that seemed to be missing—and the manuscript has been foliated in a later hand. The manuscript is the only witness that remains of Charlotte Brontë's second novel. No other drafts survive.¹²

Modern manuscripts—that is, materials created after 1700 CE—greatly outnumber holdings of early modern, medieval, and ancient manuscript material in most research libraries.¹³ Although many important studies have been conducted on modern literary manuscripts,¹⁴ most English-language bibliographical scholarship

11. For documentation on the George Smith Memorial Bequest, see [http://searcharchives.bl.uk/primo_library/libweb/action/dlDisplay.do?docId=IAMS032-002056382&vid=IAMS_VU2&indx=1&dym=false&dscnt=1&onCampus=false&group=ALL&institution=BL&ct=search&vlf\(freeText0\)=032-002056382](http://searcharchives.bl.uk/primo_library/libweb/action/dlDisplay.do?docId=IAMS032-002056382&vid=IAMS_VU2&indx=1&dym=false&dscnt=1&onCampus=false&group=ALL&institution=BL&ct=search&vlf(freeText0)=032-002056382), accessed December 20, 2020.

12. Some have speculated that the MS referred to as "John Henry" (RTC01, no. 194, Princeton University) is an early draft of *Shirley*. Historical and textual evidence show, however, that the MS is almost certainly an early draft of *The Professor*. My research on this topic is forthcoming in an essay that will appear in a new scholarly edition of *The Professor*, edited by Sara L. Pearson, to be published by Cambridge University Press.

13. Exact numbers are difficult to gauge, but the following data provides some sense of the numbers. A search conducted on October 24, 2020, for all records in WorldCat that include "manuscript" as part of the material description of holdings yielded 655,631 results for entries dating from year 1 to 1700, and 13,160,994 results for entries dating from 1701 to 2020. Of the 210,122 manuscripts and archives held by the British Library, 55,062 date before 1700, while 155,070 date from after 1700. The Morgan Library & Museum owns 2,262 medieval and Renaissance manuscripts, as compared to 62,452 "literary and historical" manuscripts.

14. Scholarship conducted on Emily Dickinson's poetry manuscripts is well known, including R. W. Franklin's foundational edition, *The Manuscript Books of Emily Dickinson* (Cambridge, MA: The Belknap Press of Harvard University Press, 1981) and Marta L. Werner's *Emily Dickinson's Open Folios: Scenes of Reading, Surfaces of Writing* (Ann Arbor: University of Michigan Press, 1995), as well as more recent studies, such as Cristanne Miller's *Emily Dickinson's Poems as She Preserved Them* (Cambridge, MA: Belknap Press of Harvard University Press, 2016). Other notable and influential studies of manuscripts include: Charles Robinson's study of Mary Shelley's "Frankenstein notebooks," which includes highly detailed information, such as beta-radiographs of the watermarks found in the notebooks; Fredson Bowers' bibliographical scholarship on the manuscripts of Walt Whitman, including *Whitman's Manuscripts: Leaves of Grass (1860): A Parallel Text* (Chicago: University of Chicago Press, [1955]); William M. Gibson's study of Mark Twain's *The Mysterious Stranger Manuscripts* (Berkeley: University of California Press, 1969); and Hans Walter Gabler's work on James Joyce's manuscripts. This is, of course, just a small sample of the important work that has been done on modern literary manuscripts. In addition, recent approaches, such as efforts in the so-called genetic editing of manuscripts, have brought increased attention to the study of modern literary manuscripts in Europe, particularly in France and Germany.

on manuscripts still concentrates on pre-modern documents.¹⁵ The term “codicology” therefore may hold little meaning for English-language scholars interested in nineteenth-century materials.¹⁶ Even so, this systematic way of studying the structures of manuscripts takes into account all kinds of material evidence crucial for understanding how authors composed their works. Supplies such as writing instruments, inks, and paper stocks, along with processes such as ruling, copying, excising and inserting, paginating, and binding, can usefully (and sometimes critically) inform our understanding of how writing is composed, revised, or otherwise altered. Additional information, including how individuals other than authors (e.g., printers, publishers, later owners, bookbinders, curators, and conservators) have altered manuscripts, is essential for understanding exactly whose “hands”—and whose handiwork—we see when we ourselves handle and study these artifacts.

It may surprise some readers that the Brontës’ literary manuscripts have not yet received this kind of close codicological and bibliographical attention, given the sisters’ international fame and cultural stature. Scholars have tended to rely on biographical explanations for interpreting the Brontës’ manuscripts. Some of these assessments have focused on the patriarchal systems and cultural conditions that challenged and limited the work of nineteenth-century women writers. Other accounts have traced the Brontës’ writing practices to imaginative and even unconscious, trance-like states.¹⁷ Few have attempted a more holistic and methodical examination of the documents’ material construction.

In the case of *Shirley*, Charlotte Brontë made numerous partial-leaf excisions to her fair-copy manuscript in the late spring and summer of 1849 as part of late-stage revisions to its text before handing over the manuscript to her publisher in September of that year. These visible extractions have intrigued and puzzled the handful of scholars and editors who have worked closely with the novel’s three manuscript volumes. Most of these writers have discussed the excisions in connec-

15. Of the four leading English-language scholarly journals specifically devoted to manuscript studies, three focus exclusively on pre-modern documents: *Manuscripta*, *Scripta*, and *Manuscript Studies*. The notable outlier is *Manuscript Cultures*, a periodical founded in 2008 that is published in both English and German by the University of Hamburg’s Centre for the Study of Manuscript Cultures. *Manuscripta*, founded in 1957 and currently edited by Gregory Pass, publishes research on medieval and Renaissance manuscripts, with a focus on “material aspects of the production, distribution, reception, and transmission of pre-modern manuscripts”; <https://www.brepols.net/series/MSS>, accessed August 19, 2022. *Scripta: An International Journal of Codicology and Palaeography*, started in 2008 and edited by Fabrizio Serra, publishes scholarship in English, French, and Italian that focuses on the intersection of ancient and medieval manuscripts, with an emphasis on “the history of written manuscripts in European and Mediterranean civilization”; <http://www.libraweb.net/riviste.php?chiave=89>, accessed August 19, 2022. The journal *Manuscript Studies*, recently launched in 2016 by the University of Pennsylvania’s Schoenberg Institute for Manuscript Studies, “embraces the full complexity of global manuscript studies in the digital age,” while maintaining a focus on “pre-modern” manuscript cultures; <https://mss.pennpress.org/home/>, accessed August 19, 2022. *English Manuscript Studies, 1100–1700*, which ran from 1989 to 2007, did not include research on modern manuscripts.

16. Donald H. Reiman’s monograph *The Study of Modern Manuscripts: Public, Confidential, and Private* (Baltimore: The Johns Hopkins University Press, 1993) makes only a passing reference to developments in codicology and paleography in the preface of his work (ix).

17. Barbara Heritage, “Reading the Writing Desk: Charlotte Brontë’s Instruments and Authorial Craft,” in “Romantic Women and their Books,” ed. Michelle Levy and Andrew Stauffer, special issue, *Studies in Romanticism* 60, no. 4 (Winter 2021): 509–10.

tion with the deaths of Charlotte Brontë's three remaining siblings—Branwell, Emily, and Anne—which took place while the novel was still awaiting completion. They have described with poignance the deep grief that Brontë endured, and they have speculated about the particular challenges that she likely faced in response to her profound loss—accounts that have impressed subsequent generations of readers and writers. At the same time, the perceived impact of this loss has overshadowed other details of importance pertaining to the manuscript: why the excisions were made, when they were made, and how they relate to the overall material structure of the manuscript in its many stages of composition.

The present study offers a fresh interpretation of the manuscript and, by extension, Charlotte Brontë's own practices as a woman writer. Here I have attempted to provide an intensive analysis of the manuscript's physical features—its paper, leaf and page numbering, inks, excisions, and insertions—by drawing on a variety of bibliographical and codicological methods that, taken together, yield new insight into Brontë's compositional practices. The evidence resulting from this analysis calls into question standard critical accounts of how the manuscript was composed and edited. My findings include the discovery of late additions, significant expansions, and previously undetected revisions that are documented within the very structure of the manuscript. Hidden within plain sight, these changes bear silent but powerful witness to Brontë's strategic approach to crafting her narrative. At the same time, when interpreted alongside Brontë's correspondence, these alterations to the manuscript tell a more nuanced story of the woman writer at work. Among the strata of the manuscript's leaves, we can trace gaps in writing when Brontë was primarily serving as a caregiver for her dying siblings. The manuscript was inadvertently shaped by these caregiving duties, which required Brontë's emotional and physical attention and which often took priority over the labor of writing itself. The manuscript thus makes material the kinds of hard, practical challenges that women writers such as Charlotte Brontë faced in caring for their families while pursuing careers as authors.

Modern manuscripts, like all historical artifacts, are subject to alteration and modification over time—their handling by compositors and press readers, the sequences of their leaves (whether unbound or as the result of a later binding process), and even their contents, in the event that new leaves are introduced or existing leaves are repaired. In the case of *Shirley*, the manuscript has been significantly altered through interventions made by those who have been in contact with it over more than a century and a half.

The manuscript volumes thus present various strata of data—different forms of handwriting, numbering, and leaf placement—that are the result of various agencies at work, sometimes with different intentions that are not clearly delineated as such. The surviving manuscript of *Shirley* is not just the product of one individual, but of many—not a solo aria, but rather like a chorus that is, at times, discordant. Just as one must attune one's ear to identify different voices and instruments in the study of music, we must train our eyes to read various hands and the work of their tools.

Brontë composed *Shirley* as a three-volume novel, and its narrative is contingent on its intended format in three parts, its word count, its pacing—and, as we

shall see, its physical structure. Each of the three novels that Charlotte Brontë wrote and that were published during her lifetime—*Jane Eyre*, *Shirley*, and *Villette*¹⁸—were formulated and composed for publication as three-volume novels in print.¹⁹ Her publisher specifically sought novels in this format to meet the demands of circulating libraries, whose terms and conditions, in turn, proved lucrative for both parties.²⁰ As others have noted, the divisions between volumes were integral to the novel's overall structure and plot.²¹ The complex editorial process underlying *Shirley*'s own three-volume structure is made apparent, in part, by evidence found in paper stocks—a bibliographical analysis that can usefully inform our critical interpretations with regard not only to the novel's shape, but also its meaning.

Since *Shirley*'s initial publication in 1849, much of the criticism on the novel has had to do with the unity of its structure or the lack thereof. George Henry Lewes, who had so warmly championed *Jane Eyre* after its publication in 1847, asserts in an unsigned review that Currer Bell's second published novel is "not a picture; but a portfolio of random sketches."²² He writes: "The book may be laid down at any chapter, and almost any chapter might be omitted."²³ This strand of criticism has continued in various forms into the twenty-first century. Various rationales have been proposed for Brontë's organization of *Shirley*. The novel's collage-like quality, perceived as a flaw by Lewes for its lack of "artistic fusion,"²⁴ has been interpreted by others as a deliberate, experimental approach. For instance, in her chapter "The Terrible Handwriting: *Shirley*," Heather Glen interprets *Shirley* as a "self-conscious play with the fictional medium itself"²⁵—a heteroglossia, cacophony of voices not unlike the Tower of Babel, which, as Glen shows, was both the subject of other artists known to the Brontës and a shaping influence on them.²⁶

In their respective analyses and opposing views, Lewes and Glen both gesture toward physical media—the portfolio and handwriting—to make their points. But for Lewes and Glen, these analogies are merely figurative; they are not intended to refer to the actual physical presentation of Brontë's manuscript, which holds little interest for them, despite the intriguing parallels their comparisons suggest. Lewes speaks of the "portfolio" of the visual artist, while Glen considers not the handwrit-

18. Charlotte Brontë's first full novel, *The Professor*, was not written as a three-volume novel, and was published only after her death in 1857.

19. Brontë dated the end of the first volume *Shirley*, for example, and sent it separately to her publishers for review in February 1849. For an analysis of the three-volume format of the fair-copy manuscript of *Jane Eyre* and its composition as such, see Barbara Heritage, "Authors and Bookmakers: *Jane Eyre* in the Marketplace," *The Papers of the Bibliographical Society of America*, 106, no. 4 (2012): 449–85 (472–75).

20. It was Brontë, however, who determined the content, pacing, and divisions. See "Authors and Bookmakers," 472–75.

21. See "Novelists, Novels, and the Establishment: From George Eliot and George Gissing: The Novelist's Viewpoint," in Guinevere L. Griest's *Mudie's Circulating Library & the Victorian Novel* (Newton Abbot, Devon: David & Charles, 1970), 87–119.

22. Lewes, "*Shirley: a Tale*. By Currer Bell, Author of 'Jane Eyre,'" *The Edinburgh Review*, no. 183 (January 1850): 160.

23. Lewes, "*Shirley*," 159.

24. *Ibid.*

25. Heather Glen, *Charlotte Brontë: The Imagination in History* (Oxford: Oxford University Press, 2002), 147.

26. Glen, *Imagination in History*, 168–69.

ing of manuscripts but rather "that terrible handwriting of human destiny, illness and death," as perceived by George Eliot²⁷—a grappling with the grave consequences of sickness, social isolation, and loss that, indeed, mark the novel's very core.

At the same time, these comparisons raise tantalizing questions both about the circumstances underlying the creation of the manuscript and the ways in which scholars have talked about its composition. Is there any evidence in the manuscript that accounts for the novel's feeling of disunity or discord? Is this sense of random disjunction, observed by Lewes and others, reflected in the actual structure of the manuscript itself? Any attempt to address these questions requires a close study of the document and its physical construction.

1. THE CURRENT STATE OF THE MANUSCRIPT

Even a quick glance at the fair-copy manuscript of *Shirley* suggests that many hands have modified the manuscript since it left Charlotte Brontë's custody. Currently, volumes 1 and 3 are three-quarter bound in boards covered in brown goatskin and fine-grained book cloth. These recent bindings date from August 1976, when volumes 1 and 3 of the manuscript were rebound by the BL,²⁸ according to a "Record of Treatment" tipped in onto the rectos of the first of three rear free endpapers.²⁹ Volume 2 of the manuscript is still in a binding that was likely commissioned by Brontë's publisher, George Smith. The binding of volume 2 consists of worn, three-quarter tan calf and boards covered in marbled paper, in a manner typical of the last quarter of the nineteenth century; the volume contains light brown uncoated endpapers with a single flyleaf at the front appearing to have been introduced as part of the binding process.³⁰ When the BL later rebound volumes 1 and 3 in 1976, the binders discarded the endpapers, but they

27. Glen, *Imagination in History*, 186.

28. The spines of the 1976 rebound are decorated as follows: covered in brown goatskin, they feature six compartments and five raised bands (double ruling in blind around each raised band). Reading from the head of the spine down: the top compartment is empty, except for a new, white shelf mark label that reads "\$667 | A"; the second compartment contains a deep maroon spine label that reads as follows: "[double rule in gold] | SHIRLEY [in gold] | [single rule in gold] | M. S. S. [in gold] | [double rule in gold]"; the third compartment is empty; the fourth compartment contains the following lettering tooled in gold: "VOL. | I [III]"; the fifth compartment contains the following text tooled in gold: "GEORGE SMITH | MEMORIAL | VOL. IV [VI]"; the sixth compartment contains the following text tooled in gold: "BRITISH LIBRARY | ADDITIONAL | MS. | 43,477 [43,479]".

29. The record of treatment documents that "RS" examined volume 1 of the manuscript, Add MS 43477, "after binding" on 24.8.76. Volume 3, Add MS 43479, is also documented as having been examined by "RS" on the same day.

30. The following is a description for the spine of volume 2. The original spine is of brown leather (appears to be calf) with six compartments and five raised bands (each raised band tooled in gold with double rule) with a deep maroon spine label located in the second compartment ["SHIRLEY"] tooled in gold: top compartment blank, aside from a sticker label with the old shelfmark "670" canceled in pencil; in second compartment from top: "[double rule in gold] | SHIRLEY. | [single rule] | M. S. S. | [double rule in gold]"; third compartment empty; fourth compartment: "VOL. | II."; fifth compartment: "GEORGE SMITH | MEMORIAL. | VOL. V."; sixth compartment: "BRIT. MUS. | ADDITIONAL | MS. | 43,478. | [old shelf mark label at bottom with the following letter in pencil] B". These library markings were tooled onto the spine in the twentieth century.

retained the older fly-leaves and preserved the original spines of the nineteenth-century bindings by gluing them onto the front pastedowns of the new bindings. The lower compartments of all three original spines bear the British Museum's library manuscript number stamped in gold.³¹

Although such information may seem peripheral to the study of Brontë's own document, it is crucial for any editor or critic to note. Any time a book is rebound, additional materials can be introduced into its structure; the leaves of a manuscript can be removed or added to—or reorganized and joined in various ways—particularly in this case, in which they have been supplemented and altered. Often binders and conservators will make repairs to paper leaves as part of the rebinding process. Such alterations can materially influence the shape of a work. (I once discovered, for instance, that one of Brontë's early manuscripts, held in a leading research library, had been rearranged and digitized out of order after it had been treated by a conservator, who was presumably well intentioned but apparently unfamiliar with the manuscript's textual contents.) Today, professional conservators routinely and very carefully document their alterations to books, a trend that started in the 1970s according to Cathleen Baker.³² In the nineteenth century, however, bookbinders who performed restoration work did not usually note their modifications. Even with respect to changes made in the twentieth century, one cannot rely on accurate recordkeeping. For example, the BL has no documentation available outlining any former alterations made to the paper leaves of the manuscript volumes of *Shirley*—a troubling oversight, as this valuable manuscript bears many excisions and repairs, as well as additions and rearrangements.

To undertake my study, I created a table to document the manuscript's paper stocks, its multiple forms of leaf and page numbering, its writing media (i.e., different colored inks and pencil), its excisions, the compositors' markup, and other notable features (e.g., paper repairs, sewing holes, &c.). Using a light sheet, I moved through the manuscript, page by page, recording this information for all of its 896 leaves; I performed this work at the BL twice, first in 2017, and then again in 2019 to check my earlier work and to record additional details about the manuscript's leaf and page numbering, which turned out to be more complicated than expected.

Paper-based evidence confirms that one full wove leaf (vol. 1, BM f. 215) was added to the manuscript as part of its nineteenth-century binding—an alteration that was also documented by the British Museum staff when they officially accessioned the manuscript in 1949.³³ This full leaf apparently replaced a fragment of a leaf that had been so heavily excised by Brontë and, consequently, so small,

31. The British Museum accessioned the manuscript of *Shirley* only in 1949. The BM, however, routinely tooled information onto non-institutional bindings during that time period—a fact worth noting, given that this alteration was not documented in writing. I am grateful to Karen Limper-Herz both for confirming that this was a practice of the BM, and for sharing her opinion about the date of the original bindings. We both independently determined that they dated from the last quarter of the nineteenth century.

32. Cathleen Baker addressed this issue as part of a discussion she led on RBS Online in October 28, 2020: "How Making Paper by Hand and by Machine Impacts Its Characteristics."

33. The note reads: "the blank leaf between ff.214 & 216, inserted in place of the original f. 215, was in its present position when the MS. was received in the B.M." The note is written in blue pen on the label appearing on the verso of the first of three endpapers at the back of volume 1, Add MS 43477.

that it appears to have been lost before the manuscript was first bound at the instruction of George Smith.³⁴ Later, another full wove leaf (BM f. 22, vol. 1) seems to have been added by the BL conservators during the 1976 rebind to fill in a gap in the manuscript's foliation—an omission, notably, in the numbering to the leaves falling between the novel's first and second chapters, but entailing no loss to the text.³⁵ We will return to this detail, which is significant.

Drawing on this evidence, as well as the chronology of the binding work itself, we can deduce who made the paper repairs to Brontë's partial-leaf excisions. Except for two early repairs made by Brontë herself, all of the repairs to the leaves in the second volume of the manuscript appear to have been made as part of the nineteenth-century binding.³⁶ How can one tell? The second volume was not rebound by the BL, and so many of the leaves (particularly those whose partial-leaf excisions run the full width of the leaf) could not have been guarded or safely patched without first disbinding the volume. Notably, the red ink of the British Museum stamp, applied to the versos of select leaves of the manuscript when it was accessioned in 1949, appears on top of one of these pre-existing repairs (BM f. 10). Of the fifteen partial-leaf excisions³⁷ in volume 2 unrepaired by Brontë, only four (or 27%) were patched with new partial leaves pasted onto the versos of the leaves to stabilize them.³⁸ The glue used to affix these nineteenth-century patches has damaged the manuscript's leaves in places, probably owing

34. Following the text of the 1849 London edition of *Shirley*, this missing fragment would have read as follows, "where, and whom she would. Rose was to have a fine, generous soul, a noble intellect profoundly cultivated, a heart as true as steel, but the manner to attract was not to be hers." (See p. 204 of volume 1 of the London edition, printed by Smith, Elder, or p. 174 of the Clarendon edition.) Presumably, the excised text that followed the fragment pertained to Rose Yorke's inability to attract others. This interpretation must remain speculative, given that the proof sheets do not survive.

35. Unlike BM f. 215, this blank leaf was not noted as being in the manuscript when it was accessioned. Also, this leaf was not foliated with the other leaves in 1949, and it matches the same wove paper used to mount all of the leaves for the 1976 BL rebinding.

36. Both of the repairs made by Brontë in volume 2 entail textual changes in the running texts falling on BM ff. 270 and 280. BM f. 270 consists of two joined fragments of leaves: the first fragment is 8.65 cm tall (9 lines); the second fragment is 6 cm tall (6 lines). Both are 18.5 cm wide (as with all other leaves in the MS). Both the cut at the bottom edge of the upper fragment and the cut at the top edge of the lower fragment are wavy, suggesting that Brontë excised a portion of text from the middle of a full leaf, and then joined the upper and lower fragments together. The upper leaf is pasted on top of the upper portion of the lower leaf. No marginal stub from the original MS appears to be present, suggesting that the leaf may have been a singleton—hence the necessity for joining the fragments resulting from the excision. BM f. 280 consists of a similar case: two fragments of leaves were mended together; the upper leaf is pasted on top of upper portion of the lower leaf. The upper fragment measures from 4.1 to 5 cm in height, and the lower fragment 11.2 to 11.7 cm in height. Taken together, the entire mended leaf measures 16 cm tall.

37. There are 17 partial-leaf excisions in volume 2; yet one of them, BM f. 159, which has been "counted" as an excision by past editors and tracked as such in this study, is likely a half-leaf insertion that entailed no removal of text from the MS.

38. It appears that the aim of that first series of nineteenth-century repairs was to stabilize vulnerable leaves that had been heavily excised in the middle—but not the half-sheet excisions or smaller excisions made by Brontë to the tops or bottoms of leaves. The wove paper used to repair these leaves appears to match the aforementioned white wove paper at BM f. 215, vol. 1, which consists of a blank leaf paginated in pencil brackets in a nineteenth-century hand.

to the adhesive's high acidic content. In addition, these older repairs³⁹ are identifiable as such, as they bear visible acid damage from the iron gall ink that Brontë used—damage that is not yet visible on the more recent repairs made to the manuscript in the twentieth century.⁴⁰

In contrast, four (or 57 %) of the seven leaves bearing partial-leaf excisions in BL-bound volume 3 have been repaired. These patches appear to be made with paper matching the blank, unpaginated, full wove cream-colored leaf (BM f. 22, vol. 1) inserted into volume 1 during the 1976 rebind, as well as the paper of the new guards used to mount the leaves in volumes 1 and 3 as part of the conservation and rebinding process. The paste used to make these repairs does not exhibit the damage evident to the earlier repairs made in volume 2. And, tellingly, the BM stamp appears neither on these repairs nor in the center of unrepaired leaves (as it does in the second volume), but rather on the remaining fragmentary portions at the margins of the leaves (e.g., BM ff. 99 and 100, vol. 3). Why is this so? Either the excised central portions of these leaves were still unrepaired and missing when the BM accessioned and stamped the binding nearly thirty years earlier; or cruder repairs already made in the nineteenth century were replaced by the BL as part of the 1976 conservation of manuscript volumes 1 and 3. Residual damage to the paper affecting the original leaf, but not to the wove repair itself, suggests that the latter could have been the case. No repairs were made to the four excisions in volume 1, beyond the two leaves that Brontë mended herself (BM ff. 126 and 144).⁴¹

2. BRONTË'S ALTERATIONS TO THE MANUSCRIPT

Having established the scope of the binders' and conservators' interventions, we can now turn to Charlotte Brontë's own work with the volumes. This aspect of the manuscript requires more interpretation and bibliographical analysis, as much of the evidence pertaining to Brontë's own alterations has been either destroyed or hidden.

The current manuscript consists of 896 leaves, including both the leaf added during the BL rebind and the replacement leaf added during the nineteenth-century binding of the manuscript. Volume 1 contains 284 leaves; volume 2 consists of 289 leaves; and volume 3 includes 323 leaves. Volume 3 appears to have been originally planned on a scale similar with volumes 1 and 2, but, as we shall see, it was expanded in the late stages of the novel's composition. In all, Brontë's fair copy would have consisted of 895 leaves.

39. See, for example, the repair to BM f. 10, vol. 2.

40. For a detailed description of nineteenth-century writing ink, see chapter three, pp. 33–46, of Thomas Griffiths' *The Writing Desk and Its Contents* (London: John W. Parker, 1844).

41. With respect to BM f. 126, vol. 1, Brontë added a footnote that was likely included to replace a stanza of poetry that was probably excised. With respect to BM f. 144, it appears as though she removed two lines from within the leaf following the poem and preceding the narrator's wry comment about the poem *not* reflecting on the relationship between Caroline and Robert Moore. The fragments were joined by Brontë, but a gap remains unrepaired following "Robin-a-Rec."

The manuscript contains a number of conspicuous partial-leaf excisions that require interpretation. Although one critic has speculated that the paper was cut away with sewing scissors, it is more likely that Brontë made the excisions with the blade of a quill cutter⁴² to remove portions of leaves (and their text) from the manuscript during various stages of its composition and revision. I note 28 partial-leaf excisions made by Brontë—just one more than was identified by Herbert Rosengarten and Margaret Smith, the editors of the 1979 Clarendon edition, which remains the most textually authoritative edition of the novel to date.⁴³ Rosengarten and Smith argue that these partial-leaf excisions, combined with other revisions to the document, “reflect Charlotte’s difficulties in writing the novel.”⁴⁴ Surveying the many changes made to volumes 2 and 3, they note Brontë’s “‘dark and desolate’ period of bereavement in 1849,” and they argue that, when compared to the fair-copy manuscript volumes of *Jane Eyre*, the manuscript volumes of *Shirley* offer “physical evidence of Charlotte’s greater uncertainty of composition and more laborious revision.”⁴⁵ Notably, the Clarendon editors rely on a biographical explanation for many of these changes, including the weight of Emily Brontë’s death on her sister: the “painful, even raw, reality, that will not, perhaps, easily be adapted into the fictional framework.”⁴⁶ One comes away with the overwhelming sense that the excisions to the manuscript are akin to scars—physical scars—resulting from the real and multiple traumas that Brontë endured while writing it. Recently this sentiment has been echoed, if not somewhat distorted, by another critic, who characterizes the manuscript as “a text of grief” that “makes material a sorrowful mind.”⁴⁷ Yet, while the death of Charlotte Brontë’s sisters unquestionably influenced the writing of the novel, this tendency to interpret the manuscript through the lens of biography has obscured our understanding of it. So powerful has been the pull of this wrenching

42. I discuss these aspects in more detail below with respect to Ileana Marin’s study of the manuscript.

43. The Clarendon edition of *Shirley* uses the first edition as its copy text, and incorporates emendations “wherever possible” from the manuscript or second edition. As part of that enterprise, editors Rosengarten and Smith attempt to identify all of the significant revisions that Brontë made to the manuscript; their careful analysis was limited, however, by their methods in examining the manuscript itself. The various states of the manuscript and its stages of composition become evident when analyzing the paper stocks along with the manuscript’s multiple forms of leaf/page numbering. The Clarendon editors do not identify the former (it was not part of the scope of their project), and they document the latter only in part. Notably, the final page-numbering so often referred to by scholars was not made by Brontë at all, but rather was the work of BM curators who foliated the manuscript in the twentieth century—circumstances that I describe in more detail below.

44. *Shirley*, Clarendon edition, xxvi.

45. *Ibid.*

46. *Shirley*, Clarendon edition, xxvii.

47. In *The Brontë Cabinet*, Deborah Lutz claims that the “alterations and deletions multiply” in volume 3—the portion of the manuscript written after Anne’s death—when in fact the majority of excisions occur in volumes 1 and 2. She does not cite her sources, other than correspondence collected in Margaret Smith’s edition, so it is unclear how she came to this particular conclusion. See *The Brontë Cabinet: Three Lives in Nine Objects* (New York: W. W. Norton & Company, 2015), 184.

biographical narrative that it has overshadowed other evidence that the manuscript holds about the story of its own making.

A close study of the manuscript's paper and leaf and page numbering reveals that a number of expansions were made to the manuscript, as well as significant revisions (in the way of removed and recopied leaves). In all, Brontë added 51 leaves to the manuscript. This includes 22 leaves of new material that she incorporated into the manuscript while modifying her fair-copy manuscript—the most notable being a ten-leaf expansion to the chapter “Written in the Schoolroom” in volume 3 that I discovered as part of this study.⁴⁸ In addition, 29 leaves bear evidence of having been added to the manuscript by Brontë as part of a later stage of extensive revision and recopying.⁴⁹ The most significant group among these particular leaves are those that replaced Brontë's original first chapter, strongly suggesting that she revised and recopied it. This new evidence challenges the long-held scholarly belief that Brontë resolutely refused to modify her first chapter despite pressure from her publisher to alter it.⁵⁰ Lastly, I found that Brontë probably removed 32 leaves from the manuscript at various stages during which she copied and recopied it; many of these changes were part of an early state of the manuscript and its copy text, and they can be identified by studying Brontë's leaf numberings made in pencil within the manuscript. Some of these removed leaves were replaced with new, expanded material—most of which was copied out on fresh bifolia; in other instances, Brontë appears to have dropped substantial sections of text from the novel. All in all, including the 28 partial-leaf excisions, Brontë made 111 changes either to the leaf size or to the codicological structure of the manuscript, amounting to approximately 12% of its combined total of 896 leaves.⁵¹

This new data counters the findings of a 2013 article published in *Brontë Studies* that claims that Brontë's activities while revising *Shirley* were chiefly aimed at removing text from her manuscript. In her article, Ileana Marin interprets

48. Only eight of these 22 new leaves were identified by the Clarendon editors as definitively being part of any expansion to the manuscript—their focus being on the “late insertion of the ‘Femme Savante’ essay in chapter 27” (xxv; also see p. xxvii). The expansion to “Written in the Schoolroom” has not, to date, been documented (so far as I can tell) by any editor or scholar.

49. The Clarendon editors missed the majority of these, although they speculated in two instances that leaves could have been introduced owing to “rewritten or expanded material.” In their introduction, the editors note a repetition in the numbering of ff. 299 and 300 in volume 2 “possibly because new material had been added” (xxv). The Clarendon edition does not track penciled numbering (or lack of) or red numbering, but later notes some additional differences in numbering: “Leaf 43, which contains less text than usual, may be rewritten. Leaves 42 and 43 were originally numbered 324 and 325; no original number is visible on f. 44; ff. 45 and 46 were also numbered 324 and 325: perhaps the error was caused by an insertion of rewritten or expanded material” (see p. 269). In this case, one of these leaves appears to be recopied material (or text of approximately the same length as what was cut), while three new leaves of material were added, increasing the overall numbering of leaves in volume 2. See table 2 below.

50. Rosengarten and Smith note that “the readers at Cornhill were disturbed by Charlotte's satire on the Church” and write that “Charlotte would not withdraw the offending chapter.” *Shirley*, Clarendon edition, xix.

51. This figure does not include the four repairs that Brontë made to leaves. The BM/BL leaf count of 896 leaves includes f. 22 from volume 1—a leaf that they added to the manuscript to replace a leaf that was almost certainly removed by Brontë as part of the revision of chapter 1.

Brontë's excisions as a deliberate attempt to conceal and "censor" its content from her publishers: "Charlotte came up with a system of revision that allowed her to conceal from her publishers the revision process and bolster her identity as a professional writer. . . . The pressure of conceiving female characters that did not seem to be the schematic creations of a female author meant to Charlotte that she would need to excise passages which might have betrayed personal details about the author."⁵² The result, according to Marin, is "a more fragmented narrative."⁵³ She identifies these excisions as the "symptoms of a writing disorder or disease," which she calls the "Jane Eyre' complex":

The Jane Eyre complex describes the author's contradictory desire to reveal and conceal personal, even intimate or offensive, occurrences in her own life. . . . She understood that the interpretation of her first readers (Smith and Williams) was decisive for the publication of her work and thus used the process of revision to withdraw or, more accurately, to censor what seemed to her excessive, exaggerated, or too explicit references to her personal life, even willing to jeopardize the novel's narrative coherence by doing so.⁵⁴

It is unusual to claim that any author who was deliberately preparing a novel for publication would feel the need to censor her own fair copy after writing it out, and Marin does not provide any parallel instances for the purposes of comparison. Instead, she pursues an interpretation that centers on the anxiety of the woman author, and turns to fiction for her answers. Material and mind mimic one another: the novel's apparent fragmentation lacks coherence and serves as a mirror of Brontë's own psychological "disorder." The partial-leaf excisions are evidence of a form of self-censorship and psychological withdrawal. Life, in this instance, imitates art; the process of revising the manuscript reenacts conflicts apparent in the narratives of Brontë's own novels.

This interpretation is problematic for a number of reasons. First, the claim pursues a reading of the manuscript that subjects Brontë herself to the kind of "suspicious" and gendering gaze that, according to Marin, Brontë sought to avoid. In doing so, Marin's analysis reinscribes the flawed, essentialist notion of the woman writer as a neurotic (the infamous "madwoman in the attic" analogy that feminists both invoked and, in some cases, later fought to dispel⁵⁵) without

52. Ileana Marin, "Charlotte Brontë's Heron Scissors: Cancellations and Excisions in the Manuscript of *Shirley*," *Brontë Studies* 38, no. 1 (2013): 19–20. I also cite this study in my article, "Reading the Writing Desk"; see pp. 512–18.

53. Marin, "Charlotte Brontë's Heron Scissors," 27.

54. Marin, "Charlotte Brontë's Heron Scissors," 25.

55. In *The Madwoman in the Attic*, Sandra Gilbert and Susan Gubar seek to identify the "anxieties out of which this tradition [of women writing] must have grown." Yet their model itself is diagnostic, comparing woman authorship to the "splitting or distribution of her identity"—a kind of "schizophrenia of authorship." Charlotte Brontë is singled out as providing "a paradigm of many distinctively female anxieties and abilities." See Sandra M. Gilbert and Susan Gubar, *The Madwoman in the Attic: The Woman Writer and the Nineteenth-Century Literary Imagination* (New Haven; London: Yale University Press, 1984), xi, xii, 69. More recently, feminists such as Nina Baym and Marta Caminero-Santangelo have drawn attention to the problematic nature of the "madwoman metaphor" and the kind of dichotomous thinking that "identifies women with irrationality in the first place." See Caminero-Santangelo's book *The Madwoman Can't Speak: Or Why Insanity Is Not Subversive* (Ithaca: Cornell University Press, 1998), 1–2.

taking into consideration the routine activities of the manuscript-making process itself. The reading also conflates Brontë's identity with her work—a fallacy that is traceable to earlier feminist studies, such as Sandra Gilbert and Susan Gubar's landmark study *The Madwoman in the Attic*, which employ metaphors of illness (in the case of Gilbert and Gubar, "female schizophrenia" and "dis-ease") in an effort to identify the very real, adverse effects of patriarchal structures on nineteenth-century women writers.⁵⁶ The result in this instance is an argument that purports to be based on material evidence but that hinges on a literal psychological diagnosis of a woman author who surely deserves less armchair analysis—and instead more bibliographical attention—from her twenty-first-century critics.

Finally, Marin's study offers up an interpretation of the manuscript that is at odds with its material construction.⁵⁷ Marin argues that only two of the 28 excisions that Brontë made entailed any substitution with another text—evidence that leads her to conclude that Brontë was intent on merely eliminating passages from the novel.⁵⁸ Yet, of the 28 excisions that I have documented, 11 excisions entail textual changes, including substantial revisions that required either the recopying of leaves or the addition of new leaves that expanded the length of the manuscript. And so, by my calculation, 39% of the excisions present in the manuscript were made as part of a series of substantial, later-stage revisions or expansions to the manuscript—some of which actually increased its size, rather than reducing it. Brontë often excised the upper or lower portions of leaves owing to changes made to the content in the sections of leaves falling between them. These inserted leaves bear new writing that, at a casual glance, seem to be part of one continuous draft. When taking additional leaf removals into account along with partial-leaf excisions, there are a total of 41 instances of removals that entailed expansions. In short, when Brontë removed either full leaves or portions of them, it was often with the aim of introducing new or revised content.

3. PAPER AS EVIDENCE

To investigate how a manuscript was composed and edited—and to identify any excisions or revisions made to it—requires a very close look at its physical structure. Although much evidence has been lost as a result of the way in which

56. Gilbert and Gubar, *Madwoman in the Attic*, 69, 71. Also see Mary Jacobus, review of *The Madwoman in the Attic: The Woman Writer and the Nineteenth-Century Literary Imagination* and *Shakespeare's Sisters: Feminist Essays on Women Poets*, by Sandra M. Gilbert and Susan Gubar, *Signs* 6, no. 3 (1981): 519. <https://www.jstor.org/stable/3173761>. For more discussion about these points, see "Reading the Writing Desk," pp. 504, 512–13.

57. Marin's brief description of the manuscript considerably deviates from established documentation about it. In her analysis, Marin mentions 906 folios (see p. 27)—numbers that do not reflect either the Clarendon analysis (which she cites just once in her article) or the 896-leaf count of the British Museum and BL. Her count likely includes some combination of endpapers or fly-leaves inserted by bookbinders. In addition, Marin mentions 28 excisions (p. 27), but her footnote (p. 29) lists just 25 leaves bearing excisions—and this list includes five leaves that are entirely intact, per my own direct examination of the manuscript and also the study of the Clarendon editors: BM ff. 149 and 150, vol. 1; BM ff. 9, 45, and 252, vol. 2. It is unclear how Marin identified these intact leaves as bearing excisions.

58. Marin, "Charlotte Brontë's Heron Scissors," 27.

the manuscript of *Shirley* has been bound and rebound, its paper stocks can offer substantial information about its production and Brontë's own writing practice.

Charlotte Brontë used four different varieties of high-grade stationery to copy out her manuscript. As described in more detail below, the writing paper she used was sold in quires or partial quires of nested bifolia. Each bifolium consisted of two leaves or four pages. Although the leaves in the manuscript are not uniform in height, at 18.3 cm wide they are now all uniform in width, suggesting that the manuscript was trimmed for the purposes of binding. These bifolia would have measured 38 cm wide or thereabouts when opened, but the size would have slightly varied among manufacturers. The four paper stocks included in the manuscript are:

- (1) London Superfine, a high-quality wove paper measuring 23.2 cm tall, with a blind-embossed stationer's crest often appearing, when visible, in the upper left-hand corners of the rectos of both leaves of the bifolium (though often much fainter, if present, on the second leaf) and containing the (embossed) lettering "LONDON | SUPERFINE" inside a circle; the crest features an embossed crown in its center;
- (2) Cream Laid, another high-quality paper of approximately the same height as London Superfine, and exhibiting chain lines and wirelines that appear to be real, as opposed to being made with a dandy roll; here, when visible, the embossed stationer's crest features the words "CREAM | LAID" within an oblong octagon, positioned as described above;
- (3) Royal Superfine, a smooth-surface (possibly glazed) laid paper that is noticeably shorter, measuring 22.65 cm; when visible, the stationer's crest contains the words "ROYAL | SUPERFINE", again inside a circle, featuring an embossed crown in its center, positioned as described above; and
- (4) A laid paper, likely made by the Whatman firm, with a crown, shield, and posthorn with a pendant cursive "W" watermark; its watermark is positioned as when appearing in a quarto format (i.e., across the fold and running parallel to the top and bottom edges of the bifolium);⁵⁹ a very small, round watermark crest frequently appears in the position where stationers' crests usually are embossed (i.e., the upper left-hand corner of the recto of the closed bifolium—or the crown side of the sheet), though *not* on second leaf of the bifolium (i.e., the "W" side); this paper measures 22.6 cm in height.

The average dimension of a leaf from the manuscript in its present state is about 18 cm wide by 23 cm tall—or about 7 by 9 inches. Using a dip pen, Brontë copied out her novels onto the rectos of these leaves when creating her fair copy manuscripts.

Prior to making her fair copies, Brontë's drafting process was quite different. She tended to use both sides of the leaf while initially composing her writing—sometimes drafting her manuscripts on smaller (and likely less expensive) papers and writing in pencil, as we can see in the portions of the manuscript for

59. Stationery was cut down from larger sheets; see below for more details on the original full sheet size.

"Emma."⁶⁰ When she did use larger, fine writing papers for drafting her work, she either folded the pre-made bifolia in half, creating smaller units, in which she wrote on both sides of the leaf, or else she carefully tore them in half, again using both sides of the paper for drafting her work.⁶¹ These pencil drafts were able to fit easily within her portable writing desk, which has been preserved by the Brontë Parsonage Museum.⁶²

All the extant fair copies of Charlotte Brontë's major novels were written on high-quality writing paper typically described by mid-nineteenth-century stationers as "quarto-size" or "post."⁶³ Local stationers, such as John Greenwood of Haworth, would have sold paper in quires from reams or half-reams. Indeed, Greenwood told Charlotte Brontë's first biographer, Elizabeth Gaskell, that he walked ten miles to Halifax on many occasions to buy half-reams of paper to try and ensure that he had a ready supply of paper for the Brontë sisters: "When I was out of stock, I was always afraid of their coming; they seemed so distressed about it, if I had none."⁶⁴ Only some of these letter papers bear watermarks; as described earlier, nearly all are marked by stationers'

60. The MS for "Emma" (RTCoi no. 196 in the Robert H. Taylor Collection of Princeton University) measures 12 cm wide by 18.4 cm tall. It is difficult to ascertain the original format of the manuscript, which has been rebound. However, it seems to be a gathering of ten bifolia. The manuscript is copied out onto what appear to be nested bifolia in the form of an incompletely drafted quire. The paper is a laid paper with an embossed emblem of three flowers with stems and leaves inside a circle that appears in the uppermost left-hand side of the rectos of the first ten foliated leaves of the manuscript; the embossings gradually diminish, suggesting that it was embossed as a nested quire.

61. The MS of "John Henry" (RTCoi no. 194 in the Robert H. Taylor Collection of Princeton University) was copied out onto Satin Post, a wove paper without watermarks. Brontë folded the letter paper in half, creating smaller quartos, as is apparent by the fact that watermark crests are visible on leaves one through seven; the point of the shield-like crest points not toward the bottom of the leaf, but toward the gutter. The leaves measure 11.5 cm wide by 18.2 cm tall, or 4.5 inches wide by 7.2 inches tall. The MS referred to as "Henry Hastings" (HEW 1.4.14 in the Harry Elkins Widener Collection) contains half-sheets; see leaves five and eight of the third quire. The former leaf is torn along the top, while the latter is torn along the bottom edge.

62. A second writing desk exists that is believed to have been owned by Charlotte Brontë. The desk is held in NYPL's Berg Collection. It does not contain writing materials, however, but rather a memorial card for Brontë as well as a lock of her own hair, which suggests that it was most recently used by Arthur Bell Nicholls, her husband, as a receptacle for memorabilia.

63. Large sheets of post writing paper were sold in sizes measuring about 15.5 by 18 inches (or 38.1 by 45.72 cm)—advertised dimensions varied—before they were cut into halves and then folded. Indeed, a half-sheet of this size, when cut parallel with the chain lines through the center of the sheet, results in a half-sheet measuring approximately 38 cm wide by 23 cm tall unfolded, and a bifolium of 19 cm wide by 23 cm tall. Additional examples are described later in this article. For measurements of uncut, unfolded sheets, see the entry for "Post" under "Writing and Printing Paper" (p. 76) in *Wyman's Dictionary of Stationery and Useful Compendium of Useful Information for the Office, Counting House, and Library* (London: Wyman & Sons, n.d. [1875]). https://www.google.com/books/edition/Wyman_s_Dictionary_of_Stationery_and_Com/uof7VoljwfkC, accessed September 7, 2020.

64. Greenwood told Gaskell that he could not keep greater quantities of paper in stock "for want of capital." See Elizabeth Gaskell, *The Life of Charlotte Brontë*, ed. Angus Easson (Oxford: Oxford University Press), 229.

crests—embossings made to the upper left-hand corner of partial quires using a pair of dies.⁶⁵

As I learned when examining the contents of the Brontës' writing desks at the Brontë Parsonage Museum in Haworth, the writing papers they used were sold in partial quires of nested bifolia measuring about 19 cm wide by 23 inches tall when closed (about 7.5 inches wide by 9 inches tall).⁶⁶ Although typically sold retail in this convenient folded form, the writing papers that Charlotte Brontë used were pre-cut, originating from larger, full-formed sheets.

Contemporary trade sources indicate that 24 sheets of writing paper made up a complete quire, as marketed for sale; and 20 quires made up a ream. For context, a full-formed sheet of "large post" writing paper is advertised as measuring about 40 by 52 cm (or 16 by 20.5 inches) alongside "quarto"-sized letter paper measuring only 20.32 cm wide by 26.67 cm tall (or 8 inches wide by 10.5 inches tall).⁶⁷ Large sheets of writing paper were advertised for sale to stationers and others by the quire, "packet" (i.e., partial ream consisting of five quires), and ream.⁶⁸ Although, as another contemporary source notes, "the post papers [were] seldom sold retail in the . . . original size . . . being usually cut in half, folded, and ploughed round the edges, forming, in that state, quarto post, the

65. Studying the septernion from Emily Brontë's desk, it became clear to me that the mark was embossed only after the bifolia were nested together: the recto of the first leaf bears a strong impression, with each following leaf bearing fainter and fainter successive impressions. This kind of evidence could prove very useful in establishing a sub-order within the drafting process itself. The other paper stock I located in Emily Brontë's desk, London Superfine, matched a paper used in the manuscript of *Shirley*. Very little has been written on the subject of stationers' crests. For an introductory overview of the use of stationers' crests, see Joe Nickell, "Stationers' Crests: A Catalog of More than 200 Embossed Paper Marks, 1835–1901," *Manuscripts* 45, no. 3 (1993): 199–216.

66. When examining the contents of Emily Brontë's desk at the Brontë Parsonage Museum (Bon1 [v]), I found two entirely unused samples of the same paper stocks that Charlotte Brontë had used for copying out her novels. One stock was the same paper I had seen in *Villette*: a laid paper with an embossed crest featuring flowers. It survived in the form of an unused partial quire: seven bifolia nested one inside another with a bright yellow string lying in the center fold. The other paper stock I located in Emily Brontë's desk, London Superfine, matched a paper used in the manuscript of *Shirley*. It was stored as a sheaf of 10 bifolia. Open, these bifolia measured 38 cm wide by 23 cm tall; closed, the width measured 19 cm. Juliet Barker's inventory of Charlotte Brontë's desk contains mention of two single "sheets" (presumably bifolia made from folded half-sheets) of unused writing paper, also of London Superfine and the flowered stock, folded so as to result in four leaves each—the smaller quarto format that Brontë used for drafting works.

67. See the entry for "Paper" in *Wyman's Dictionary of Stationery*, 76–77.

68. Ibid. Also, George Tindall describes how stationers usually only obtain 18 quires of "good" writing paper when purchasing a ream, with the outer two quires consisting of just 20 sheets each and inferior or even "worthless" paper. See his entry "Paper-making by Hand, and Finishing" (pp. 161–62) in *The Technical Educator: An Encyclopædia of Education*, vol. 3 (London: Cassell, Petter, and Galpin, 1871). https://www.google.com/books/edition/The_technical_educator_an_encyclopædia/Ky4CAAAAQAAJ.

letter-paper of the shops.⁶⁹ Stationers could also purchase pre-folded quarto-sized writing paper in 20-quire reams. Because a single gathering of 24 folded sheets would not lie flat, stationers would often break the 24-sheet quires into smaller units, for instance, into two separate groupings of 12 sheets apiece, or 24 leaves each. Thus, a complete 24-sheet quire could contain two sub-quires.

The dimensions of the unused bifolia of London Superfine in the Brontës' writing desks measure 38 cm wide by 23 cm tall when fully open, or approximately 15 by 9 inches, resulting in a ratio of 1.65—a measurement that does not conform to the standard sizes of full sheets of writing paper sold at the time, whose ratios range from 1.23 to 1.29.⁷⁰ These measurements indicate that these bifolia were indeed originally created from half-sheets, which, when folded, would have constituted quartos when compared to the original full-formed sheet—a fact confirmed by examining the Cream Laid paper that Brontë used in the manuscript of *Shirley*. Its wirelines run vertically (quarto-wise) instead of horizontally, as with a true folio, and the chain lines run from the gutters to fore-edges of the leaves.

Volume 3 of the manuscript contains one such 24-leaf quire of 12 folded, nested bifolia, where the exact position of the quire's watermarks indicate that the leaves are conjugate. Measurements of each of these partially visible watermarks suggest that the entire watermark (i.e., as it would appear on a half-sheet) would have measured about 16.2 cm.⁷¹ A study of the measurements in this particular gathering contains notable outliers in the cut of the sheets that clearly show the conjugacy of BM f. 3 and f. 22, of BM f. 7 and f. 18, of BM f. 8 and f. 17, of BM f. 10 and f. 15, and of BM f. 11 and f. 14 (see table 1).

Other partial-quire combinations were possible. Printers working from manuscript copy referred to these smaller units of nested bifolia as ternions, quaternions, quinternions, &c.⁷² Although these units could have resulted from further division and use by writers themselves, Emily Brontë's writing desk contains an intact, unused septernion, or partial quire of seven bifolia, as well as an unused partial quire of 10 nested bifolia—suggesting that larger gatherings were also commonly made up and used.⁷³

69. See p. 236 under the entry for "Paper" (pp. 235–39) in volume 2 of Luke Herbert's *The Engineer's and Mechanic's Encyclopaedia Comprehending Practical Illustrations of the Machinery and Processes Employed in Every Description of Manufacture of the British Empire* (London: Thomas Kelly, 1849). https://www.google.com/books/edition/The_Engineer_s_Mechanic_s_Encyclopaedia/69w-b8McR5EC, accessed September 15, 2024.

70. A publication published in conjunction with the Great Exhibition provides a table with the measurements of writing papers, as opposed to printing papers; see p. 945 in vol. 3 of *Reports of the Juries on the Subjects in the Thirty Classes into Which the Exhibition Was Divided* (London: Spicer Brothers and W Clowes and Sons, 1852). See https://www.google.com/books/edition/Reports_by_the_Juries_on_the_Subjects_in/YJdDAAAACAAJ, accessed August 16, 2021.

71. This measurement is easiest to detect what would have been the centermost bifolium (BM ff. 12–13) of the quire.

72. See entries for "Ternion," "Quadternion," and "Quinternion" in Charles Thomas Jacobi's *The Printer's Vocabulary* (London: The Chiswick Press, 1888). https://www.google.com/books/edition/The_Printers_Vocabulary/6oYaAAAAMAAJ, accessed August 15, 2021.

73. See previous footnote.

TABLE 1. Watermarks as evidence of conjugate leaves in the fair-copy MS of *Shirley* (vol. 3)

BM Fol.	Watermark measurement from gutter	BM Fol.	Watermark measurement from gutter
f. 1	7 cm	f. 24	8.75 cm
f. 2	7.1 cm	f. 23	8.4 cm
f. 3	10.1 cm	f. 22	5.6 cm
f. 4	8.9 cm	f. 21	7.5 cm
f. 5	8.4 cm	f. 20	7.9 cm
f. 6	8 cm	f. 19	7.85 cm
f. 7	2 cm	f. 18	14.2 cm
f. 8	2.1 cm	f. 17	14.1 cm
f. 9	8.1 cm	f. 16	7.9 cm
f. 10	9.75 cm	f. 15	6.5 cm
f. 11	9.5 cm	f. 14	6.8 cm
f. 12	8.6 cm	f. 13	7.5 cm

Because Brontë's fair-copy manuscript of *Shirley* has been bound, disbound, and rebound again, it is unclear exactly how all of these bifolia were arranged. The evidence suggests though that Brontë did not unnest the quires and copy out her novel on loose two-leaf bifolia arranged sequentially, one after the other, but rather that she wrote the manuscript within groupings such as the partial quire of 12 bifolia described earlier, as well as in smaller subquires, ranging from quinter-nions, sexternions, and septernions to larger subquires of 10 and 11 bifolia. The manuscript seems to reflect the kind of relative diminishment of the impressions of the embossed stationers' crest within each subquire, as observed in the septernion found in Emily Brontë's desk.⁷⁴ Tellingly, the first chapter of volume 1 of *Shirley* is written on 21 leaves, and the stationers' crest is clearly visible on the first leaf, and only faintly visible of leaves two through four—and not visible at all until an odd leaf is introduced (BM f. 21) that was recycled from prior use as a title-page. Had Brontë separated out the bifolia and/or cut them into single leaves before using them, this relative diminishment of the blind-stamped stationers' crests from leaf to leaf would not occur in any sort of regular order; it would be random.

The drafts of Brontë's other extant manuscripts that were unfinished and left unbound, as well as earlier works, such as the manuscript commonly referred to

74. See note 65 above.

as “Henry Hastings” at Harvard, are written in nested partial quires.⁷⁵ Keeping this information in mind, it seems significant that almost all of the longer revisions or expansions to *Shirley* that required additional paper were copied out in *even* numbers of leaves, suggesting the insertion of nested bifolia—the largest being the revision to the first chapter, which was likely copied out onto a new quire consisting of 20 leaves, or ten folded half-sheets. Although the leaves are no longer conjugate (i.e., joined over the folds) and the structure cannot be ascertained, other manuscripts made by Brontë contain partial quires close in size.⁷⁶ Notably, the chapters as they were first copied out in the manuscript vary in length: one chapter is as brief as 13 leaves, while another is as long as 39-and-a-half leaves.

According to Gaskell, Brontë educated herself about how to prepare a manuscript for publication by obtaining a manual on the subject.⁷⁷ Studying this guide, Brontë would have learned about matters ranging from the kinds of paper and handwriting typically preferred by publishers to strategies for gauging the length and sale potential of a work. It is apparent that, in preparing her fair-copy manuscript for submission to a publisher, Brontë followed the general practices of the day. According to Saunders and Otley’s *Advice to Authors*, a resource that Brontë likely consulted,⁷⁸ it was “much better . . . to write on separate sheets of paper, taking care to number the sheets, or folios” than to write in “pretty copy-books,” as was “the fashion much cherished by ladies.” Copybooks, the manual notes, “must be torn to pieces before they are put upon the compositors’ cases.”⁷⁹

One of the writing papers that Brontë used while copying out *Shirley* bears an embossed stationer’s mark reading “London Superfine,” a substrate that was noted for being a high-grade paper made entirely from linen rags.⁸⁰ London Superfine was not inexpensive. Typically sold in reams of 480 “sheets” (i.e., half-sheets), superfine writing papers like those Brontë used could have cost anywhere from six to eighteen shillings per ream—a sizable sum for a woman with limited means. In 1841, Charlotte Brontë had earned a meager salary of just £20 a

75. The draft MS for Brontë’s last, unfinished novel, “Emma” (RTCoI no. 196 in the Robert H. Taylor Collection of Princeton University), was written within what appears to be a nested quire of ten folios. Ten leaves of the original MS have writing composed on them (leaves two through eleven); and ten were left blank (leaf one, plus leaves twelve through twenty). And the “Henry Hastings” MS (HEW 1.4.14 Harry Elkins Widener Collection) consists of two ten-leaf quires, a 16-leaf quire, and a four-leaf quire; these folia were made from half sheets of the larger letter papers she used. The juvenilia were also copied out in quires, albeit smaller ones. For a description of this process, see Barbara Heritage, “Charlotte Brontë’s ‘Chinese Fac-similes’: A Comparative Approach to Interpreting the Materials of Authorial Labour and Artistic Process,” in *Charlotte Brontë, Embodiment and the Material World*, ed. Justine Pizzo and Eleanor Houghton (Cham, Switzerland: Palgrave Macmillan, 2020), 210–212.

76. See the previous note, describing the format of “Emma,” which contains a 20-leaf quire. Another unbound manuscript, “Henry Hastings,” contains a 16-leaf quire.

77. Gaskell, *The Life of Charlotte Brontë*, 231, 526.

78. See Heritage, “Authors and Bookmakers,” 470–71. Gaskell notes the publisher in her MS: “a small volume, published by Saunders & Otley.”

79. *Advice to Authors* (London: Saunders and Otley, n.d.), 6–7.

80. From the *London Encyclopedia*: “Rags are sold to the paper-makers sorted into four or five different kinds: No. 1, sometimes called London superfine, being all linen, and reserved for the finest paper,” 551. https://www.google.com/books/edition/The_London_Encyclopaedia/J3JMAAAAMAAJ, accessed September 7, 2020.

year, or about seven-and-a-half shillings a week, while working as a governess at Upperwood House in Rawdon, West Yorkshire; her small income was further reduced by a deduction of about £4 per annum for laundry. Her younger sister, Anne, was paid £40 a year (or £10 per quarter) for her work as a governess at Thorpe Green Hall—about 15 shillings per week.⁸¹ That was considered to be a very favorable salary—one near the upper end of the range for what a governess could earn at that time. And so one ream of high-grade “post”—or the approximate amount of paper that Brontë required for copying out *Shirley*—could have easily cost a woman employed as a governess an entire week of her salary, if not more. Although Brontë's earning potential had significantly increased as of 1847 with the sale of *Jane Eyre*, the cost of paper was still not inconsequential.⁸²

In *Advice to Authors*, Brontë would have read that it was “common practice . . . to write only on one side of the leaf, and to leave the opposite, or under page, blank.”⁸³ This is generally the practice she followed. But instead of ruling her own paper or purchasing pre-ruled paper (as is suggested by *Advice to Authors*), Brontë likely used a separate, heavily ruled leaf of paper, such as the one kept in her writing desk, to slip under the surface of her letter paper.⁸⁴ When I placed the extant ruled leaf from Brontë's desk under a leaf of London Superfine paper stock, its dark lines showed through the writing paper, which suggests that the leaf could have readily served as a guide for the copying of her manuscripts. The use of a ruled leaf would have allowed Brontë to regulate the number of lines per page and thus systematize the pace and flow of her novels.⁸⁵

If this were the case, the ruled leaf that Brontë used would have provided a margin of at least 2 cm on the left-hand side of each bifolium onto which she wrote out the fair copies of her manuscripts—an inference supported by the fairly uniform registration of the leaves in the manuscript of *Shirley*. Part of this left-hand margin could have been removed at the printing house if the bifolia were sliced instead of slit; the remaining margin was likely trimmed yet again as part of the later binding process commissioned by George Smith. Brontë copied out her novel nearly flush with the right-hand margin of the leaves; occasionally

81. Juliet Barker, *The Brontës* (London: Weidenfeld and Nicolson, 1994), 351.

82. Brontë was paid £100 for the copyright of *Jane Eyre*, and received an additional £400 in payments for the novel. She was paid £500 for *Shirley*. *Letters*, 1:541, 2:262.

83. *Advice to Authors* (London: Saunders and Otley, n.d.), 7.

84. Ruled leaves were ephemeral, and created on an *ad hoc* basis. The extant ruled leaf that I studied at the Brontë Parsonage Museum in 2019 is made of wove paper. It measures 19.25 cm wide (across the leaf); 23 cm long (top to bottom). The leaf was ruled in pencil first, then in ink. It was made of a thicker weight paper than the other writing papers I found in her desk. This example has a 1.1 cm margin on the left side of the template. The lines were ruled approximately 1 cm apart from one another, with 21 lines ruled on the leaf, allowing for 22 spaces for text. I identified two small holes punctured into the sheet above and below line 6 from the bottom of the device.

85. Brontë came to adopt the use of a ruled leaf later in her process as a writer. The outset of her first manuscript intended for publication, “The Professor,” does not seem to follow any systematic ruling—nor do the earlier manuscripts generally referred to as the juvenilia. But she employed a ruled leaf consistently afterward in composing her manuscripts for *Jane Eyre*, *Shirley*, and *Villette*. See “Authors and Bookmakers,” 473. (In 2012, I detected the use of a ruled surface in the fair-copy manuscript of *Jane Eyre*, before locating an example of a ruled leaf, which I was able to do in 2019, during my research into the extant contents of the Brontës' writing desks.)

her writing touches their very edges, but without any loss to the text. She usually left just a centimeter of space—the same space she interposed between the lines of her text—at the top and bottom of each page, except at the ends and beginnings of some chapters.

The layout of the manuscript text, with its substantial left-hand margin—which she did not use when making corrections—suggests that the leaves could have been loosely sewn or otherwise temporarily bound. Whether or not Brontë did this is unclear; I have noted the presence of needle marks and holes in the left margins of the leaves, but those holes appear in the first and third volumes of the manuscript, and could have resulted from its nineteenth-century binding, before the leaves were individually mounted and rebound by the British Library. At the same time, any leaves bearing partial excisions would have been extremely frail and liable to tearing before they were repaired as part of the binding process; for this reason, it is quite possible that Brontë lightly bound her volumes in some fashion.

4. CORRELATION OF PAPER STOCKS AND VARIANT LEAF NUMBERING

As Brontë copied out her novel in ink onto high-grade writing paper from her smaller-sized penciled drafts, she first numbered the leaves of the fair copy in pencil before inking over the numbers at a later state of the manuscript's preparation.⁸⁶ This underlying numbering in pencil, previously unnoted by scholars as far as I can tell, may have correlated to how she initially paginated her pencil drafts, which no longer survive.⁸⁷ By the same token, the absence of these

86. Brontë tended to foliate instead of paginate her fair-copy MSS. I used the term "numbering" to avoid any confusion with respect to this process, as well as to distinguish her numbering process from the BM's own foliation of the manuscript. Brontë did paginate the verso of one leaf where she added writing intended for publication: BM f. 267 in volume 3, Add MS 43479, which she numbered as 834 and 835 in the C state of her numbering system (outlined in more detail below). Notably, the BM only foliated the leaf on its recto. The only other instance in which Brontë added content to a verso intended for publication in *Shirley* can be found on BM f. 236 in volume 2, Add MS 43478. This addendum, which was marked by an asterisk, makes a sarcastic reference to how Currer Bell was "charmed to meet with a complete exposition" on governesses in the January 1849 issue of *The Quarterly*—a not-so-veiled riposte to Elizabeth Rigby's severe critique of *Jane Eyre* in the December 1848 issue of *The Quarterly*. This wording was intended to replace a portion of canceled text on BM f. 237, vol. 2; in the end, Brontë decided to cancel both, likely in light of her publisher's express wish to exclude the defensive preface in response to *The Quarterly* from the published book.

87. Because no working drafts for *Shirley* survive, this interpretation must remain speculative. Yet extant working drafts for other writings shed some light on her process. Although Brontë used smaller-sized paper and formats to draft her novels, she foliated just the rectos, not the versos, of her late pencil drafts; because both sides of the leaves bore writing, it seems that one recto and verso combined essentially worked out to the same approximate length of writing appearing on the recto of the larger-sized writing paper. We see this system at work with Brontë's last draft for a novel, "Emma" (RTCOR no. 196 in the Robert H. Taylor Collection of Princeton University): the leaves measure 11.5 cm wide by 17.8 cm tall—approximately half the size of the full letter papers that Brontë used for making her fair copies—and she foliated her writing by the leaf, not by the page.

numbers can also prove meaningful, as Brontë generally did not pencil in her numbering in her later rounds of editing when introducing new material into the manuscript; she simply numbered the leaf in ink instead (see table 3).

In all, there are five different forms of numbering in the manuscript of *Shirley*. In chronological order, they are as follows:

- (A) the initial penciled sequence of numbers, possibly corresponding with numbering in Brontë's penciled drafts;⁸⁸
- (B) numbers that Brontë copied in brown ink over her earlier penciled numbers and that occasionally vary from those underlying penciled numbers—thus reflecting changes she likely made during the initial process of copying out the manuscript;
- (C) numbering that Brontë made in a now-faded red ink (identified as a “new series of numbers in brown ink” by the Clarendon editors⁸⁹) that was introduced as part of her first significant revision of the manuscript after she had fully copied out volume 3 in July and August of 1849;
- (D) a brief sequence of numbers made by Brontë in brown ink and pencil (referred to by the Clarendon editors as “three sequences” of “two cancelled numbering sequences” [xxv]) that corrects the red sequence in the middle of the third volume, after Brontë introduced yet another late, but significant, expansion to the novel in September of 1849;⁹⁰ and
- (E) the penciled foliation made by British Museum staff a century later in 1949. The librarians took the liberty of striking through *all* of Charlotte Brontë's own numbering as they inserted their own penciled foliation on the leaves in accordance with what appears to have been the standard, if reprehensible, practice in the BM at the time. (The foliation is documented by the staff on labels applied to the rear free endpapers in volumes 2 and 3 of the manuscript.⁹¹)

Both the Clarendon editors and Marin generally refer to these later BM numbers when describing the manuscript—the former occasionally referring to

88. See the previous footnote. There is a further nuance to Brontë's numbering system that is difficult to capture without introducing ambiguity into my own system for tracking it; technically, as will be seen, the leaf numbering for the first chapter is likely not part of the “A” and “B” sequences described—but part of a later pencil-and-ink revision. Introducing an additional sequence of letters for the purposes of making this distinction seems unhelpful, given the confusion it would likely introduce into the overall order of the manuscript's composition.

89. *Shirley*, Clarendon, xxv.

90. These changes were made to the chapter titled “The Last Blue-Stocking,” which Brontë revised at the behest of her publishers—a case alluded to briefly before and described in detail below. This last numbering sequence trails off after a few leaves. In fact, BM ff. 102 through 323 of volume 3 were never entirely renumbered by Brontë, for they were in London with her publisher, who had mailed the portion of the chapter in question to Brontë for revision.

91. The documentation in volume 1 does not clearly specify that the manuscript was foliated (or by whom), but this is doubtlessly the case, as the folio count recorded at the back of each manuscript is written in the same hand as the foliation. (Note: the foliation is clearly a different hand from Brontë's; the person who foliated the manuscripts crossed their “4”s with a tail, whereas Brontë did not.) Volume 2 is recorded as being foliated by [signature difficult to decipher], and volume 3 was foliated by “JM.”

some of Brontë's own preceding numbering in a few instances (viz., xxv, xxvii, 269)—an approach that failed to recover a great deal of additional information about the earlier stages of the manuscript's composition and revision. A full representation of the numbers on the last leaf in volume 3, in order of their chronological written sequence as delineated above, would run as follows: A873.B873.C891.[D897].E323. That is: A873[CB pencil].B873[CB brown ink].C891[CB red ink].[D897; the final numbering sequence that was discontinued by CB].E323[the BM foliation].⁹² In one glance, the sequence provides quite a bit of data—namely, that the manuscript had increased in size by 24 leaves between the time it was first copied out in full and then later revised.⁹³

By examining the different states of the manuscript's leaf (and occasional page) numbering alongside the manuscript's paper stocks, one can readily establish the various stages at which the manuscript was copied out. The great majority of volumes 1 and 2 were copied onto Cream Laid writing paper,⁹⁴ while the majority of volume 3 was copied onto London Superfine letter paper. I believe that Brontë's use of these two principal paper stocks roughly corresponds to the two main periods when she copied out her manuscript.

Although it is generally known that Brontë wrote most of *Shirley* during two different periods, there has been some question within the scholarly community as to exactly when and why the interruption occurred between her two writing stints. Examining the manuscript, it is clear that Brontë finished copying out volume 1 in September 1848, as she adds her completion date (almost exactly a year before Taylor arrived in Haworth to retrieve the volume) at the end of the volume.⁹⁵ Volume 2 is undated, but is largely written on the same laid paper stock as volume 1. In her correspondence, Brontë indicates that she "laid aside" the manuscript while she herself was ill following the death of her brother, Branwell.⁹⁶ And in a later letter to George Smith, Brontë indicates that "two-thirds of 'Shirley'" had been written while her sisters still lived and were able to respond to

92. Brontë's leaf count is one leaf longer than that of the BM as she paginated the verso of BM leaf 267 (CB leaf 835) in volume 3 of the manuscript.

93. This must be qualified, as Brontë paginated the verso of one leaf: BM f. 267 of volume 3, as indicated in the previous note.

94. Approximately 92% (261 leaves) of the paper in volume 1 is Cream Laid, with the remainder consisting of 21 leaves of London Superfine (7%) used for the first chapter of the manuscript, one leaf (BM f. 215) introduced as part of the nineteenth-century rebind, and one leaf of the twentieth-century cream-colored wove paper introduced during the BL rebind. Approximately 92% (265 leaves, or 11 + 23 + 114 + 114 + 3) of volume 2 is made up of Cream Laid, with 4% London Superfine (11 leaves, or 5 + 4 + 2) and 4% Royal Superfine (13 leaves, or 12 + 1). Approximately 12% of volume 3 is made up of laid watermarked paper (38 leaves, or 24 + 14), with 6% Cream Laid (18 leaves), and the rest, or approximately 82%, London Superfine (267 leaves).

95. Volume 1 was completed in September 1848, as dated by Brontë on the last leaf of volume 1 of the manuscript.

96. Brontë writes to W. S. Williams: "My book, alas! is laid aside for the present; both head and hand seem to have lost their cunning; imagination is pale, stagnant, mute. This incapacity chagrins me; sometimes I have a feeling of cankering care on the subject, but I combat it as well as I can; it does no good." Margaret Smith believes that the letter was written on October 18, 1848, based on the source. *Letters*, 2:128. This is the same date Clement Shorter attributed to the letter; see p. 458 of *The Brontës: Life and Letters* (London: Hodder and Stoughton, 1908).

her work.⁹⁷ Brontë's friend and biographer, the novelist Elizabeth Gaskell, seems to corroborate this history when she writes:

She had nearly finished the second volume of her tale when Branwell died,—after him Emily,—after her Anne;—the pen, laid down when there were three sisters living and loving, was taken up when one alone remained. Well might she call the first chapter that she wrote after this, "The Valley of the Shadow of Death."⁹⁸

"The Valley of the Shadow of Death" chapter mentioned by Gaskell is the first of volume 3; thus, according to Gaskell, Brontë resumed writing volume 3 only after the death of her remaining sister. In her edition of Charlotte Brontë's letters, Margaret Smith disagrees with Gaskell, suggesting that, as late as February 1849, Brontë "writes as if she had completed no more than the first volume rather than the greater part of two, as Mrs. Gaskell alleged." Smith continues: "the second volume, if she had begun it, was perhaps still in the form of a preliminary pencil-draft—CB's normal method of composition, according to the *Life*."⁹⁹

On the contrary, the evidence found in the manuscript's differing paper stocks largely corroborates Gaskell's claim, suggesting that Brontë had copied out the majority of volume 2 by late September 1848. Toward the end of volume 2, the run of Cream Laid paper abruptly ends at f. A551.B551.C557.E273—a leaf that falls in that volume's final chapter, "An Evening Out." The remaining 16 leaves of volume 2 contain a mixture of paper stocks (Royal Superfine and Cream Laid) that do not correlate with any changes to their numbering—a fact that seems to confirm that Brontë attempted to work on the manuscript intermittently. A letter written in September of 1850 also seems to confirm this. In it, Brontë recounted to James Taylor of Smith, Elder how the "great part" of *Shirley* was "written under the shadow of impending calamity" and the "last volume . . . composed in the eager, restless endeavor to combat mental sufferings that were scarcely tolerable."¹⁰⁰

Sickness had stalked the Brontë household ever since September of 1848 and had still not abated in January of 1849.¹⁰¹ After the death of her brother, Branwell, on September 24, Charlotte Brontë had increasingly found herself performing a different form of labor from that of writing: the caregiving duties of nursing her own family members. Whether soliciting medical advice for Emily (who adamantly refused it until her death in December), or attending to Anne and their

97. See Brontë letter to Smith dated October 30, 1852.

98. Gaskell, *The Life of Charlotte Brontë*, 315.

99. *Letters*, 2:182.

100. *Letters*, 2:461.

101. "All the days of winter have gone by darkly and heavily like a funeral train; since September sickness has not quitted the house." *Letters*, 2:168. The situation was rather more complex, unfolding over many prior months. Branwell's dependence on alcohol and opium had contributed to the deterioration of his health and had even disguised the symptoms of tuberculosis. As Juliet Barker notes: "Branwell's health had worsened so imperceptibly over the last eighteen months that no one had noticed how ill he had become. So often drunk or hung over, it could only be expected that his constitution would be affected. . . . Any sympathy Charlotte felt for her brother had long evaporated; now he simply irritated her." See *The Brontës* (London: Weidenfeld and Nicolson, 1995), 564–65. Branwell's father had primarily looked after him during his illness, although sometimes the sisters assisted in caring for him, particularly at night (see *Letters*, 2:93).

father, who required medicines, blisters, and other treatments, Charlotte focused on looking after her loved ones.¹⁰² In January, she writes to Williams: "My literary character is effaced for the time . . . care of Papa and Anne is necessarily my chief present object in life to the exclusion of all that could give me interest with my Publishers or their connexions."¹⁰³ Her choice of the word "effaced" is suggestive here: in her correspondence with her publishers during this period, she sought to separate "Charlotte Brontë" from "Currer Bell," indicating a pivot from the latter (masculine) identity: "Should Anne get better, I think I could rally and become Currer Bell once more."¹⁰⁴ In February 1849, when Anne showed some signs of recovery, Brontë wrote to her publisher about her attempted endeavor to resume her work on the novel, even as she continued to look after Anne, who had by that time had been diagnosed with tuberculosis. Even at this point, Charlotte seems only to have been able to return to the novel sporadically. In February, she writes: "I wish it were more than a commencement, for how it will be re-united after the long break, or how it can gather force of flow when the current has been checked—or rather drawn off so long—I know not."¹⁰⁵ It was at this point that she was likely completing work on the end of volume 2 in a series of interrupted, brief intervals, as evidenced by the varying stocks of paper, as described earlier.

Although Gaskell writes that Brontë did not begin work on volume 3 until after Anne's death, it seems clear that Brontë did draft and copy out the volume's first three chapters intermittently during the first half of 1849. Brontë's mixed use of paper continues within the first 56 leaves of volume 3—starting with "The Valley of the Shadow of Death"—which were copied out irregularly on Cream Laid paper, as well as on watermarked laid paper (yet again on leaves without any apparent alterations to their numbering). The abrupt changes in paper stocks may reflect another important fluctuation in Brontë's life at that time: the erratic intervals during which Anne's health temporarily improved before further declining.¹⁰⁶ Brontë likely wrote on whatever high-grade writing paper was at hand as she copied out her work in various spurts. She seems to have regained her momentum only toward the end of copying out these very difficult chapters, whose heroine, narrowly recovering from the brink of death, was loosely mod-

102. After Branwell's death, Charlotte became ill, and, upon recovering in the autumn, she tended to her sisters, as well as her father and their servant, Tabitha Aykroyd, who was "suffering under serious indisposition" in November 1848; see *Letters*, 2:132. Emily refused professional medical assistance as well as other treatments, such as homeopathy; see *Letters*, 2:142, 145, 146–147, 150, 152. Charlotte sought medical advice and kept a careful eye on her sister, despite Emily's dogged reluctance to be helped. Charlotte finally convinced Emily to try homeopathic medicine in early December, and she drew up a detailed account of Emily's malady; but then Emily refused to take the medicine when it was received, and she died shortly afterward. See *Letters*, 2:154. In late December, Charlotte was caring for her father and Anne, who became ill with influenza; *Letters*, 2:159, 165. In January, Charlotte was nursing Anne, which included administering and dressing blisters and giving her cod-liver oil (*Letters*, 2:166) and also ordering a respirator to help with her breathing (*Letters*, 2:171). Charlotte herself suffered from "pains" in her chest and back, which she treated with "pitch plasters and bran tea"; see *Letters*, 2:169.

103. *Letters*, 2:168.

104. *Letters*, 2:168.

105. *Letters*, 2:181.

106. See *Letters*, 2:181, 189, 191, 196.

eled on Anne. As late as May 8, 1849, Brontë writes: "I can make no promise as to when another [book] will be ready—neither my time nor my efforts are my own. That absorption in my employment to which I gave myself up without fear of doing wrong when I wrote 'Jane Eyre' would now be alike impossible and blamable; but I do what I can—and have made some little progress: we must all be patient."¹⁰⁷ Brontë made her moral obligations very clear to her publisher: Anne's well-being came first, *then* writing. She would not endanger her sister's life for the sake of completing *Shirley*.

After a prolonged and painful illness, Anne finally died on May 28 in Scarborough, where she and Charlotte had both hoped that she would eventually recover. And so Charlotte Brontë parted with the last of her six siblings, who all perished from the same dreaded disease, the "galloping consumption"—named so for the swiftness of its spread and the speed with which it killed its victims. Brontë wrote to W. S. Williams of Smith, Elder: "had a prophet warned me how I should stand in June 1849—how stripped and bereaved—had he foretold the autumn—the winter, the spring of sickness and suffering to be gone through—I should have thought—this can never be endured. It is over. Branwell—Emily—Anne are gone like dreams—gone as Maria and Elizabeth went twenty years ago."¹⁰⁸ Brontë sought work—and the labor of writing, in particular—as a remedy for the intense pain resulting from their loss. On June 25, she wrote to Williams: "Labour must be the cure, not sympathy—Labour is the only radical cure for rooted Sorrow—The society of a calm, serenely cheerful companion . . . soothes pain like a soft opiate—but I find it does not probe or heal the wound—sharper more severe means are necessary to make a remedy. Total change might do much—where that cannot be obtained—work is the best substitute."¹⁰⁹ The deliberateness of Brontë's approach contradicts those who have characterized her work at this time as "confused," uncertain, and clouded by grief.¹¹⁰ As described earlier, such assessments have inadvertently depicted Brontë as a hapless woman—her broken spirit reflected in the fractured leaves of her manuscript. It can be shown, however, that she approached her work during this period with a particularly strategic focus.

By July, Brontë had gathered her powers, resuming her work in a steady stream of London Superfine stock, which runs throughout the rest of volume 3. Indeed, codicological evidence seems to confirm that, after completing this volume, Brontë then used this same London Superfine paper stock as needed to go back and carefully revise each volume as she steadily worked to polish her novel for publication. And so while the manuscript is indeed marked by death—that "painful, even raw, reality" described by Rosengarten and Smith—her priorities were clear. The interruptions to the manuscript's completion resulted from her active efforts to save the lives of her sisters. The corresponding gaps in the

107. *Letters*, 2:206.

108. *Letters*, 2:220.

109. *Letters*, 2:224.

110. Rosengarten and Smith characterize this period as one of "uncertainty" (Clarendon edition, xxvi), while Deborah Lutz describes it as "confused" (*The Brontë Cabinet*, 184). I discuss some of the reasons and trends unpinning these interpretations in "Reading the Writing Desk," 518–19.

manuscript's paper stocks reflect her labor as a caregiver, which took precedence over her work as a writer.

In fact, the evidence suggests that Charlotte Brontë made most of the excisions and revisions largely *after* the passing of Branwell, Emily, and Anne, not concurrent with them. When interpreted in this light, the excisions are not proof of Charlotte Brontë's bewilderment or perplexed indecision, but rather evidence of her efforts to unify the novel, drawing it together after the "long break" she speaks of with respect to her writing process and that is evident in the very structure of the manuscript itself.¹¹¹ She took care to revisit the novel as a whole—to suture gaps in plot, in particular—through a carefully thought-out process of revision and expansion.

5. EXCISIONS AS EXPANSIONS

As Brontë copied out new leaves during this late stage of revision, she inserted sections of London Superfine wove paper within the laid leaves of volume 1 and volume 2 (see table 2), and thus inadvertently left evidence of her editorial interventions. These insertions constitute the entirety of chapter one of volume 1: "Levitical" (BM ff. 1–21); a five-leaf section (BM ff. 12–16) in chapter one of volume 2: "Shirley and Caroline"; a four-leaf section (BM ff. 40–43) in chapter two of volume 2: "Further Communications on Business"; and a two-leaf section (BM ff. 158–159) in chapter seven of volume 2: "Which the Genteel Reader is Recommended to Skip, Low Persons Being Here Introduced." All the wove paper sections in volume 2 were clearly later additions to the manuscript, as each wove section also exhibits variants in the numbering Brontë assigned them. The latter two sections are flanked by partial-leaf excisions—the removal of prior writing that was cut out of the manuscript's leaves in order to accommodate a combination of new and rewritten material presented in the inserted wove leaves. Note that in each instance but one,¹¹² the wove insertions lack any draft numbers in pencil, which also suggests that these leaves were not part of the manuscript in its initial state.

The following example from volume 2 helps to illustrate the practical utility of correlating differences in numbering with the manuscript's various paper stocks. In the chapter "Shirley and Caroline," a partial-leaf excision of about five lines on f. A294.B294.E10 (see figure 1) precedes an extensive revision copied out on five full leaves of London Superfine wove paper (see table 2). In this chapter, Brontë removed three from the manuscript, as is evident in the gap in penciled numbering between leaves f. A294.B294.E10 and f. A299.B299.C301.E17. She then replaced those leaves with (presumably) revised writing on three leaves of wove paper, and she also expanded the section by adding two leaves—a change apparent in the duplication of the brown-inked numbering sequence in

111. *Letters*, 2:181.

112. A penciled "11"—possibly "211"—appears preceding the "299" (BM f. 15, vol. 2). An ink blot mars the upper right-hand corner of the leaf. It is possible that this was a draft leaf for the revised version of chapter one and was damaged and later reused here. This leaf is part of a five-leaf insertion—suggesting that one loose leaf was likely inserted along with two bifolia.

TABLE 2. Paper in the fair-copy manuscript of *Shirley* (vols. 1, 2)

Paper Stock	Occurrences	Notes
<i>Volume 1</i>		
London Superfine wove	BM ff. 1–21	
C20 cream-colored wove (BL conservation)	[BM f. 22]	
Cream Laid	BM ff. 23–284	
<i>Volume 2</i>		
Cream Laid	BM ff. 1–11	<i>Last leaves in series:</i> A294.B294.E10 <i>PLE</i> A295.B295.E11
London Superfine wove	BM ff. 12–16 “Shirley and Caroline”	[A lacking].B296.E12 [A lacking].B297.E13 [A lacking].B298.E14 [A11?].B299.E15 [A lacking].B300.E16
Cream Laid	BM ff. 17–39 :	<i>First leaf in series:</i> A299.B299.C301.E17 <i>Last leaf in series</i> A321.B321.C323.E39 <i>PLE</i>
London Superfine wove	BM ff. 40–43 “Further Communications on Business”	[A lacking].B322.C324.E40 [A lacking].B323.C325.E41 [A lacking].B324.C326.E42 [A lacking].B325.C327.E43
Cream Laid	BM ff. 44–157	<i>First leaves in series:</i> [A323].B323.C328.E44 <i>PLE</i> A324.B324.C329.E45 <i>Last leaf in series:</i> A437.B437.C441.E157 <i>PLE</i>
London Superfine wove	BM ff. 158–159 “Which the Genteel Reader is Recommended to Skip ...”	[A lacking].B437.C442.E158 [A lacking].B438.C443.E159 <i>PLE (half leaf)</i>
Cream Laid	BM ff. 160–289	<i>First leaves in series:</i> [A438].B438.C444.E160 <i>PLE</i> A439.B439.C445.E161

PLE = Partial leaf excision; written material cut out and removed from leaves.

this section: [A11?].**B299**.E15 (inserted London Superfine wove paper), [A lacking].**B300**.E16 (inserted London Superfine wove paper), A299.**B299**.C301.E17 (existing Cream Laid paper), A300.**B300**.C302.E18 (existing Cream Laid paper). These two overlapping brown-ink sequences represent two different states of the MS: the numbering on the Cream Laid leaves is the earlier sequence that replicates the original pencil numbering, whereas the brown-ink numbering on the London Superfine wove leaves is likely concurrent with state C (the “red-ink state”) of the manuscript’s numbering. In fact, the red-ink numbers are first introduced in the manuscript directly following this insertion. The new numbering on the wove insertions did not need to be made in red ink, as the insertion was the first of its kind in the volume, and Brontë used red ink only to disambiguate her B sequence from her newly edited C sequence.¹¹³

The text that was extracted from the manuscript here pertained to a conversation between the novel’s two heroines, Caroline Helstone and Shirley Keeldar, who are talking about men—particularly, the “society of clever men”—at the point leading up to the removal of the leaves. In the lengthy insertion, Caroline and Shirley pursue this engaging topic, delving into a discussion about the capacity for men to continue to feel affection for the women who live with them day after day. The young women consider both the character and characteristics of Caroline’s uncle, Mr. Helstone, who, according to Caroline, “speaks of marriage as a burden.”¹¹⁴ As Caroline contemplates the wisdom of remaining unmarried, Shirley describes her own method for detecting a man with a kind heart: “we watch him, and see him kind to animals, to little children, to poor people.”¹¹⁵ Shirley, we learn, trusts to the opinion of “the little Irish beggar that comes barefoot to my door; the mouse that steals out of the cranny of the wainscot . . . the dog that licks my hand and sits beside my knee.”¹¹⁶ When Shirley questions Caroline as to whether she recognizes anyone who meets such a description, Caroline recalls Robert Moore (with whom she has already fallen in love).

These inserted leaves may serve an even greater purpose in the novel, however. The passage helps advance the novel’s marriage plot doubly, as it foreshadows Shirley’s own love for Robert’s brother, Louis. Within this newly added portion in volume 2, Caroline observes that “the old dog always comes out of his kennel and wags his tail, and whines affectionally”¹¹⁷ when Robert Moore is near; this conversation not only serves the practical purpose of discreetly communicating Caroline’s own affection for Robert to Shirley, but it also prepares Brontë’s readers to recognize a similar pattern in volume 3 when Shirley’s own dog, Tartar, shows “a single partiality” for Robert’s brother, Louis: “Tartar looked, slavered, and sighed . . . and coolly settled himself on his haunches at Louis Moore’s side. That gentleman drew the dog’s big, black-muzzled head on to his knee, patted him, and smiled one little smile to himself.”¹¹⁸ These tokens of

113. The Clarendon editors note the excision of five lines, but make no note of either the recopied leaves or the expansion; see Rosengarten and Smith, 241.

114. *Shirley*, Clarendon edition, 242.

115. *Shirley*, Clarendon edition, 243.

116. *Shirley*, Clarendon edition, 243–44.

117. *Shirley*, Clarendon edition, 244.

118. *Shirley*, Clarendon edition, 514.

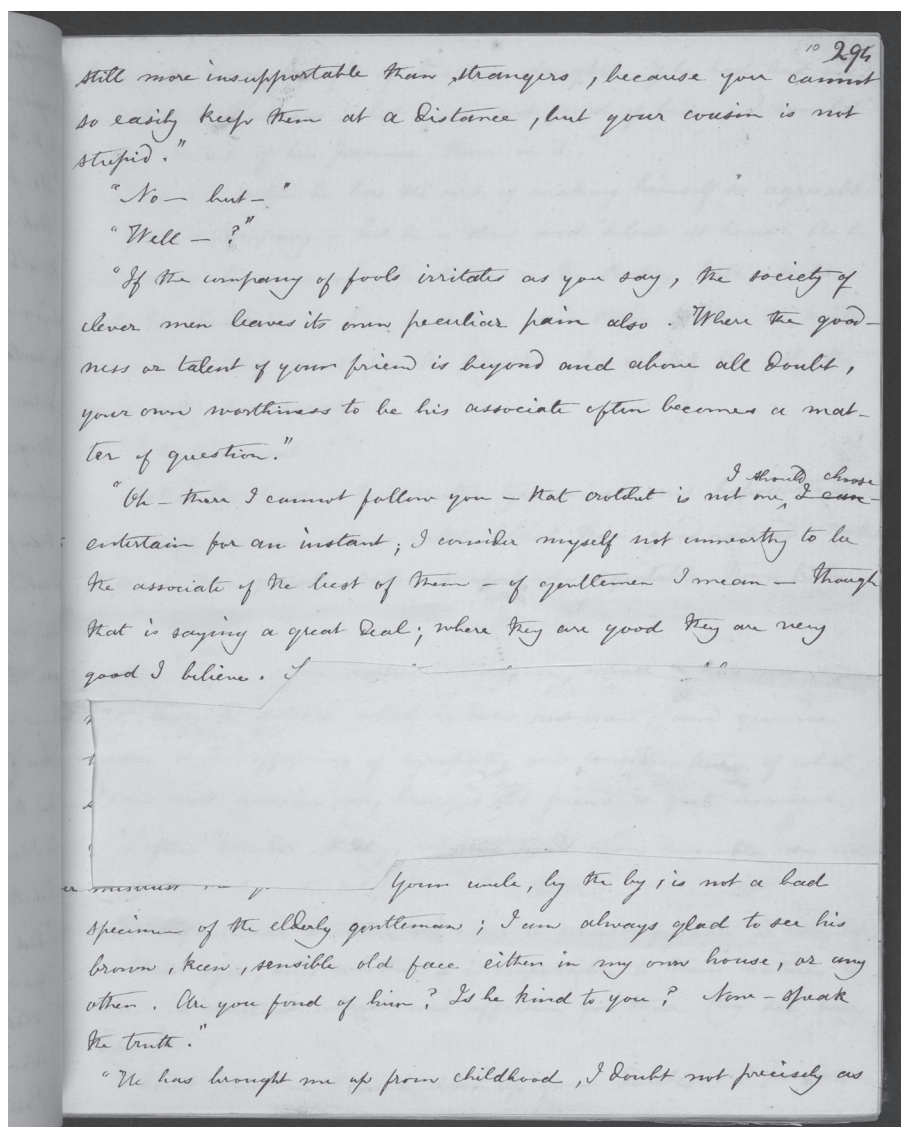


FIGURE 1. Partial-leaf excision made by Charlotte Brontë likely repaired by the binder George Smith hired in the late nineteenth century: f. A294.B294.E10. © British Library Board, f. 10, Add MS 43478.

affection convey to the careful observer that Louis is probably not only beloved by Tartar, but also by Shirley. While it is impossible to know whether the prior text extracted from volume 2 of the manuscript contained a similar description, the parallels between the two volumes seem meaningful, and it is possible that this detail was added in as a late revision to strengthen the tie.

Along the same lines, the inserted leaves in volume 2 also lay the groundwork for Shirley's eventual decision to subordinate herself to her chosen husband in volume 3. In the late addition to volume 2, Shirley proclaims on [A11?].B299.E15:

"Indisputably, a great, good, handsome man is the first of created things. . . .

"I would scorn to contend for empire with him,—I would scorn it. Shall my left hand dispute for precedence with my right?—shall my heart quarrel with my pulse?—shall my veins be jealous of the blood which fills them?"¹¹⁹

In volume 3—and in yet another late insertion consisting of a leaf of London Superfine wove paper: [A lacking]. [B lacking].C878.E310—the narrator describes Shirley's "lost privilege of liberty" leading up to her marriage:

Louis was himself obliged to direct all arrangements: he was virtually master of Field-head, weeks before he became so nominally: the least presumptuous, the kindest master that ever was; but with his lady absolute. She abdicated without a word or a struggle. . . .

In all this, Miss Keeldar partly yielded to her disposition; but a remark she made a year afterwards proved that she partly also acted on system. "Louis," she said, "would never have learned to rule, if she had not ceased to govern: the incapacity of the sovereign had developed the powers of the premier."¹²⁰

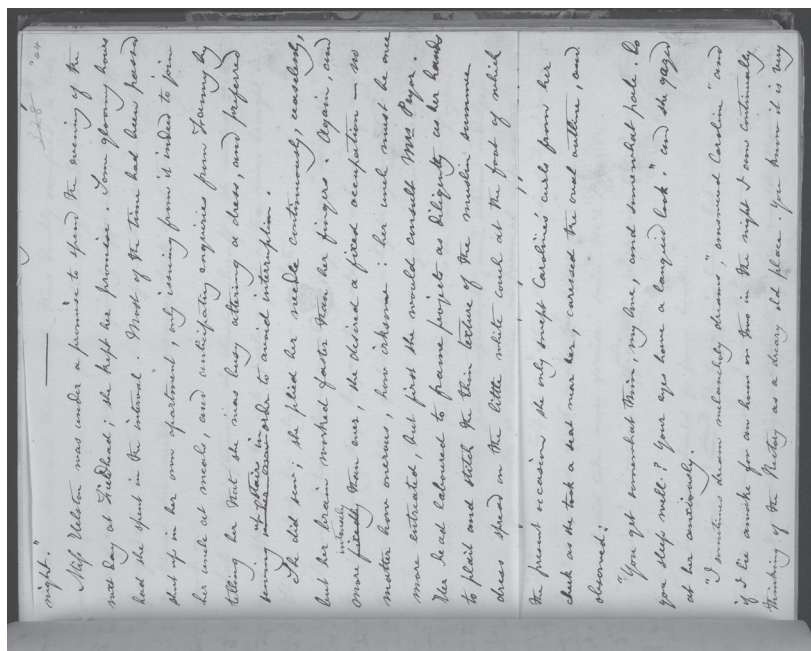
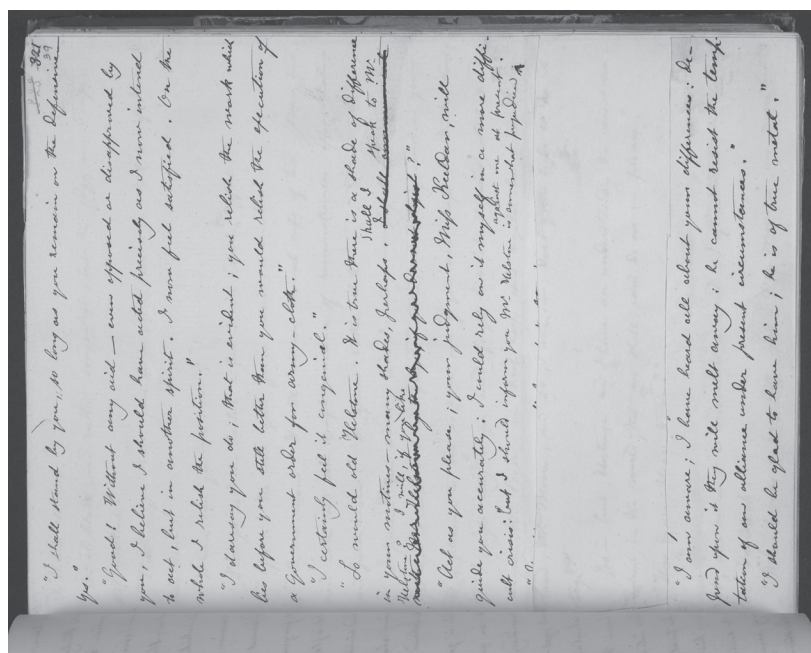
The late insertion in volume 2 helps explain why Shirley, who is usually so very independent, eventually chooses to submit herself to the authority of this man toward the end of volume 3—a development in the plot that could, in other circumstances, seem out of character.

Other instances of excision and expansion offer clear evidence of even more strategic revisions to the novel and its plot across its several volumes. Major revisions to the chapter "Further Communications on Business" entailed two partial-leaf excisions (ff. A321.B321.C323.E39 and [A323].[B323].C328.E44), the removal of one full leaf (what had been f. A322.B322), and the insertion of four wove leaves (see table 2), likely bearing approximately three pages' worth of new material—an alteration evident again not just in the changes to the paper stock, but also in differences in leaf numbering. Note that the partially excised leaf preceding the wove insertion is numbered A321.B321.C323.E39—reflecting a difference of just two leaves apparent between its brown- and red-ink sequences—and the leaf following the section of wove leaves bears the sequence A324.B324.C329.E45. The latter numbering demarcates a difference of five leaves owing to the new three-leaf expansion. This revision seems to have been made at an intermediate stage between the brown-ink and the later red-ink sequences, as *both* brown-ink and red-ink numbering are present on the wove leaves. Were this section entirely concurrent with the red-ink sequence, why would brown-ink numbering have been necessary at all? In addition, this wove section is corrected in red ink, suggesting that the red-ink numbering was introduced only as part of a later round of revision. The equivalent of one full wove leaf may have entailed some recopying of material that was revised as part of the excisions made to the adjacent leaves ff. A321.B321.C323.E39 and [A323].[B323].C328.E44 (see figures 2 and 3).¹²¹

119. *Shirley*, Clarendon edition, 245.

120. *Shirley*, Clarendon edition, 730.

121. Also see note 49 above.



FIGURES 2 AND 3. Partially excised laid leaves flanking the four-leaf wove insertion in "Communications on Business." Note that the upper half of f. [A323]. [B323]. C328.E44 was excised, and then the remaining portion moved up by Brontë and paginated in red ink. All her numbering was cancelled by the BM staff when they foliated the manuscript. © British Library Board, ff. 39 and 44, Add MS 43478.

The writing on the newly inserted wove leaves in this chapter pertains to Shirley's conversation with Robert Moore, and the addition largely has to do with Michael Hartley, who, as Shirley describes him, is a "mad Calvinist and Jacobin weaver"—a man "addicted to poaching, and often goes abroad at night with his gun."¹²² Here we learn that Moore has had an argument with Hartley. Examining this addition with respect to the novel's larger narrative structure, it becomes clear that Brontë introduced this new material pertaining to this subplot only after writing and copying out volume 3, so as to foreshadow the action to come. At the end of the third volume, and at the conclusion of the chapter "Rushedge, A Confessional," Robert Moore is shot; and we finally learn in the novel's final chapter, "The Winding-up," that it was Hartley who fired the shot: "Mr. Moore knew who had shot him, and all Briarfield knew: it was no other than Michael Hartley, the half-crazed weaver once before alluded to."¹²³ The fact that the narrator specifically makes mention of this *single* prior allusion—and the evidence of this particular insertion—offers a telling example of how Brontë's composition and fair-copy process unfolded. It seems that Brontë went back and added this extended discussion about Hartley in volume 2 to set the stage for this crucial moment.¹²⁴ Yet, it is also important to note that there are not one, but *two* prior mentions of Michael Hartley in the novel. Indeed, the first instance occurs in the first chapter of the first volume—a portion of the manuscript that may have been revised at an even later date than "Further Communications on Business," given multiple strands of bibliographical and historical evidence, discussed in more detail below. It is unclear whether the single prior allusion to Hartley described in volume 3 refers to the revised text of volume 1 or to the insertion in volume 2. If it refers to volume 2, that would combine with other factors to suggest that the first chapter was revised at an even later time. Regardless, the erroneous reference to a "single" allusion provides yet another indication that the novel was expanded to include an additional passage pertaining to Hartley very late in the process.

Before delving into the complex case of volume 1's first chapter, it is helpful to consider yet another instance of how the manuscript's excisions relate to its expansions. The insertion of two wove leaves into the chapter "Which the

122. *Shirley*, Clarendon edition, 266.

123. *Shirley*, Clarendon edition, 726.

124. One could consider whether the descender visible at the top of the excision on ff. 44 volume 2 is that of a *y*—and, by extension, postulate that this handwriting is possibly linked to some prior mention of the name "Hartley" in the earlier draft of the fair-copy manuscript of volume 2. The inserted text copied out on the new leaf ends: "Don't offer yourself as a target to Michael Hartley, and good-night!" Yet, while it is clear that the prior, extracted text likely ended in "good- | night," the spacing of this handwriting does not match that of "Hartley, and good- | night" as there is room for about two or three words—not one—between the word with the swash descender and "good"—as is evident when comparing the spacing of this excised text to that of the line below. It should also be noted that many words on the same leaf and throughout the manuscript also end in *y*—and that Brontë's letterform for *g* often contains a descender of this kind, as can be seen in the formation of the *g* in the word "altering" on this leaf. In the event that Michael Hartley was mentioned, it is clear that he was mentioned only briefly, given the extent of the material added to the manuscript in this area, which pertains almost entirely to him.

Genteel Reader is Recommended to Skip, Low Persons being Here Introduced" presents another telling instance of revision that only becomes apparent when comparing the partially excised and newly inserted material in volume 2 of the manuscript with a later expansion made to volume 3. As is evident in table 2, two wove leaves appear between two laid leaves (see figures 4 and 5) that bear both substantial partial-leaf excisions and evidence of renumbering, indicating rewriting and revision rather than an extensive expansion.

Of the two wove leaves inserted here, the second (see figure 6) is little more than a half-leaf ending with an asterisk corresponding to another asterisk appearing on laid f. [A438]. [B438]. C444. E160, where Brontë's earlier text resumes; the net gain, in terms of length, is about only a page (i.e., one side of a leaf) of additional text. Furthermore, it is clear that Brontë entirely removed some content, as the mention of Juno—still visible on the fragment of partially excised laid f. A437. B437. C441. E157—does not appear within any of the newly inserted material. Instead, the wove leaf and half-leaf contain an impassioned speech in which Shirley dismisses John Milton's depiction of Eve, and then questions both the poet's morality and his capacity to understand women:

"Milton was great; but was he good? His brain was right; how was his heart? . . . Milton tried to see the first woman; but, Cary, he saw her not." . . .

. . . "It was his cook that he saw; or it was Mrs. Gill, as I have seen her, making custards, in the heat of the summer, in the cool dairy" . . .

. . . "I would beg to remind him that the first men of the earth were Titans, and that Eve was their mother."¹²⁵

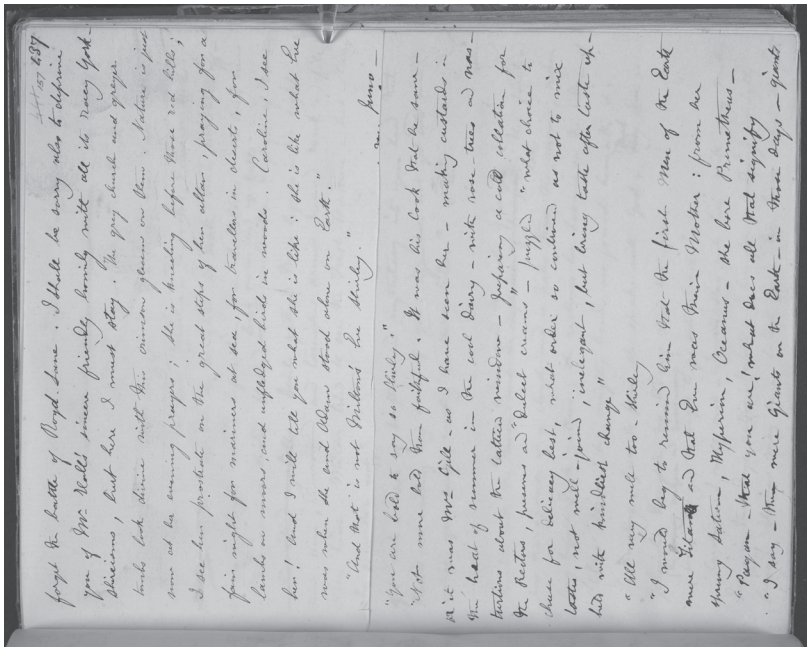
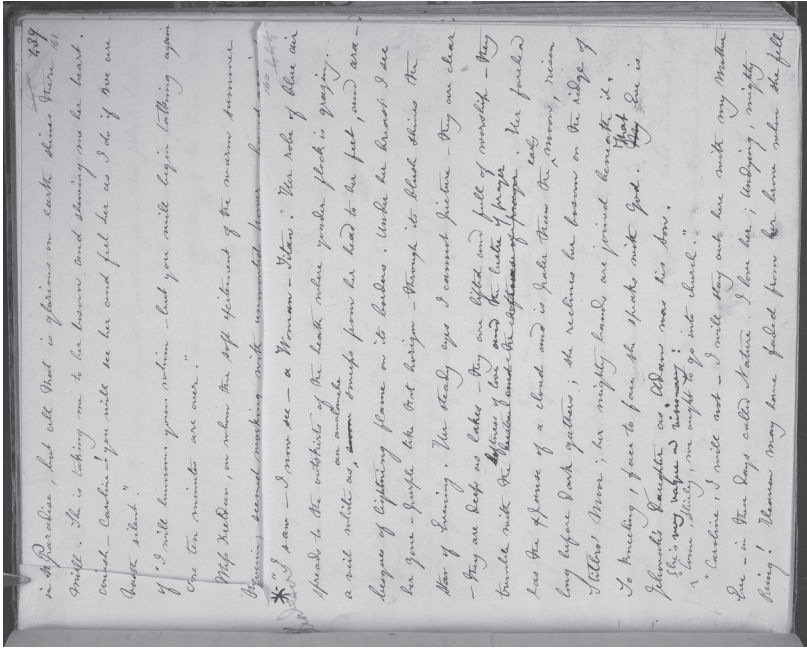
This newly added speech bears a striking resemblance in tone and content to another late expansion that we find in volume 3's chapter, "The First Blue-Stocking," which is titled as "Le Cheval dompté" ("The Tamed Horse") in the manuscript and which was only retitled as part of a later proof stage.

Although this latter chapter is entirely written on wove stock in keeping with the paper used for the majority of the third volume, variants in the chapter's numbering (see table 3) reveal that it also had been extensively revised, as has already been noted, in part, by the Clarendon editors.¹²⁶ Brontë removed a "long paragraph" in French appearing on ff. A658. B658 and A659. B659, and part of f. A660. B660 at the suggestion of her publishers; by this point, the manuscript was already in the custody of Smith, Elder, and so she requested that they mail the chapter back to her for this alteration.¹²⁷ She then drafted an English "translation," written on eight new leaves that apparently

125. *Shirley*, Clarendon edition, 359.

126. The Clarendon editors document the "substitution of an English version of the essay, 'La Première Femme Savante' (seven and a half manuscript leaves) for a letter in French which probably took up no more than two leaves. The substituted passage . . . may recall Shirley's previous vision of Eve as 'Jehovah's daughter' in volume II, chapter 7." *Shirley*, Clarendon edition, xxvii.

127. See Charlotte's letter to W. S. Williams sent in September 1849: "You observed that the French in 'Shirley' might be cavilled at—there is a long paragraph written in the French language in that chapter entitled 'Le Cheval dompté' . . . if you deem it advisable and will return the chapter—I will efface and substitute something else—in English." See *Letters*, 2:257.



FIGURES 4 AND 5. Partially excised laid leaves flanking the one-and-a-half-leaf wove insertion in "Which the Gentle Reader is Recommended to Skip. . ." The asterisk on f. [A438]. [B438]. C444. Er60 corresponds to an asterisk present on f. [A438]. C443. Er59, a half-leaf wove insertion counted as a partial-leaf "excision" but that likely entailed no loss of text. © British Library Board, ff. 157 and 160, Add MS 43478.

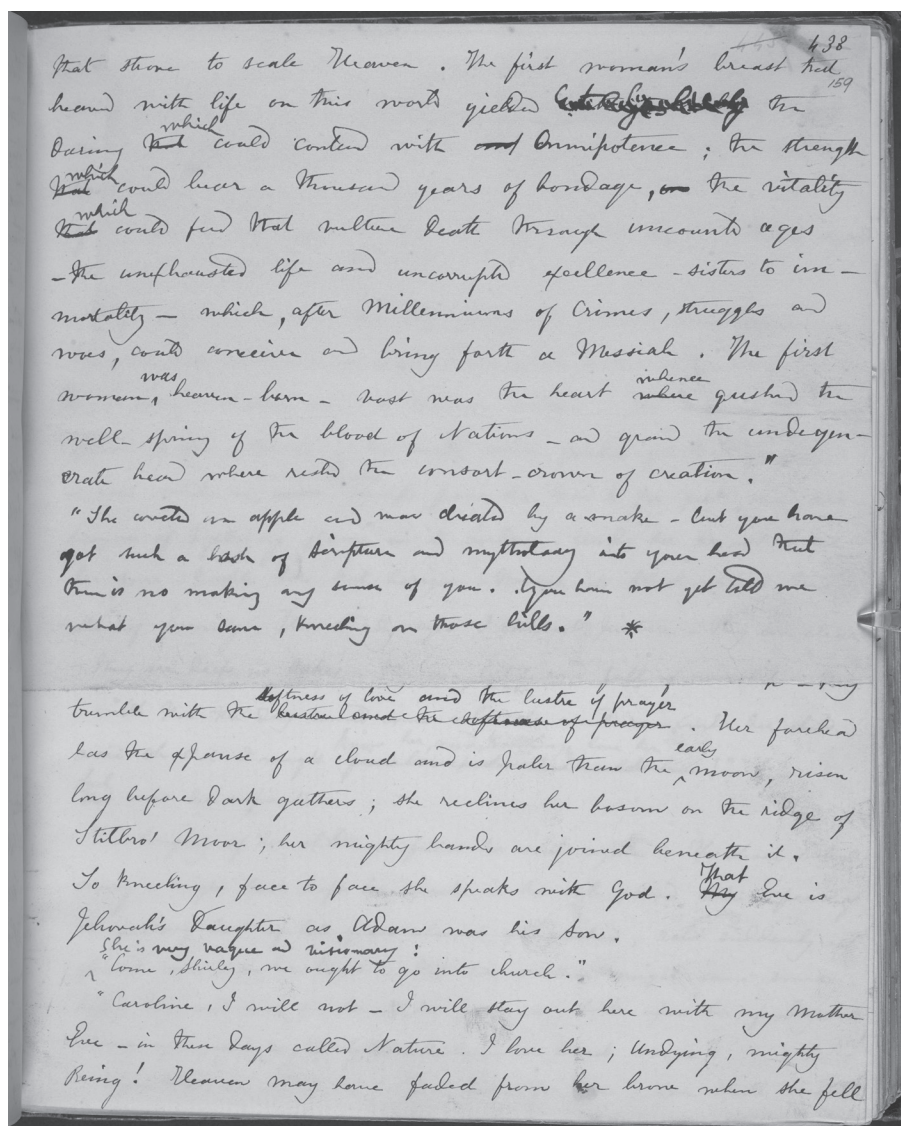


FIGURE 6. The half-leaf wove insertion f. [A lacking].B.438.C.443.E.159. The lack of any underlying pencil numbering, combined with the wove paper stock, confirms that this was a later addition, while the presence of brown numbering suggests that the alteration was made before Brontë introduced the red-ink sequence into the MS. The asterisk corresponds to the partial-leaf excision present on f. [A438].[B438].C.444.E.160. © British Library Board, f. 159, Add MS 343478.

TABLE 3. Leaf numbering in "The First Blue-Stocking" (vol. 3)

BM foliation	CB pencil	CB brown ink (1)	CB red ink	CB brown ink (2) with underlying pencil
(E state)	(A state)	(B state)	(C state)	(D state)
89	656	656	662	N/A
90	657	657	663	N/A
91	N/A	N/A	N/A	664
92	N/A	N/A	N/A	665
93	N/A	N/A	N/A	666
94	N/A	N/A	N/A	667
95	N/A	N/A	N/A	668
96	N/A	N/A	N/A	669
97	N/A	N/A	N/A	670
98	N/A	N/A	N/A	671
99	[660]	[660]	[666]	672
100	661	661	667	673
101	662	662	668	674, <i>only in pencil</i>
102	663	663	669	674, <i>only in pencil</i> ; <i>should be 675</i>
103	664	664	670	<i>No numbering; should be 676</i>
104	665	665	671	[677]
105	666	666	672	[678]
106	667	667	673	[679]

extended beyond the scope of the original paragraph, given the substantial increase in length. (The original passage in French would likely have run about two pages, and would have been introduced by dialogue.) The newly inserted leaves, which are numbered in pencil and brown ink, initiate the final "D" sequence of the manuscript's numbering, which was discontinued at A664.B664.C670.E103. Between the expansion and the discontinuation of the sequence, three leaves of the existing manuscript were renumbered (A661.B661.C667.D673.E100–A663.B663.C669.D664 [665].E102)—probably simply to clarify the positioning of the new leaves within the chapter's original sequence. Furthermore, Brontë was unable to re-number the succeeding leaves following the chapter, as she had previously done when introducing the red-ink sequence

into the novel, because the rest of the novel was already in the hands of her publisher. This explains the interruption to her red-ink numbering, as well as its disuse afterward.

The substance of the expansion has to do with Eva, "La Première Femme Savante"—the subject of a school essay, we are told, that was written by Shirley in her youth and that was subsequently memorized by her teacher, Louis Moore (Robert Moore's brother). Louis, as portrayed within the action of novel, recites the essay aloud, in its entirety, from memory.¹²⁸ Eva is Shirley's vision of an early woman, living at the dawn of time—an alternative, we intuit, to Milton's Eve, as mentioned in volume 2. Indeed, the name "Eva" appropriately carries a feminine ending, as if to demarcate the difference—reminding us that Shirley, not Milton, is the author of this particular narrative.

This dialectic is emphasized by the two sections, which cross-inform one another. Because the meditation on Eva comes later in the novel, it serves both as a corrective to the Eve of *Paradise Lost* and as a more complete re-imagining of Eve as she might have been. Yet, in the chronology of Shirley's own life, Shirley writes her essay on Eva *before* she delivers her diatribe against Milton to Caroline Helstone. As a result, when we read the novel's last volume, we recall Shirley's prior criticism, and we realize that Shirley, as a schoolgirl, had already supplied a vision of her own to challenge the Miltonic Eve that she later disputes as a grown woman. Indeed, it is Shirley who seems most befitting of the title "femme savante"—a heroine also worthy of carrying the title of this particular novel.

Because these two episodes appear within different volumes—and across the gap of time when Brontë "laid aside" her work—an intervention was likely necessary in order to tighten the parallel between the sections. As with the prior examples of "Shirley and Caroline" and also "Further Communications on Business," the insertion in volume 2 lays the groundwork for a later passage in volume 3.¹²⁹ Here it is certain, however, that the revision to volume 2 preceded that to volume 3, as we know that the addition of the long "Eva" text was introduced extremely late in the process.

6. ANALYSIS OF MISSING AND RECYCLED LEAVES

With each of the prior three examples, changes in foliation and page numbering correlate to the use of different paper stocks, and so help to establish the scope and approximate order in which Brontë modified her manuscript. How then do we approach the question of the first chapter, "Levitical," which is not only written on London Superfine wove stock but, notably, is also the only part of volume 1 not written on Cream Laid paper? This is surely significant when we recall that London Superfine wove paper stock appears in volume 2 only in

128. The narrator "translates" Louis Moore's recitation of the essay "on pain of being unintelligible to some readers." See f. D664.Eg1.

129. At the time the insertion was made to volume 2, the passage it corresponded with would have the short essay in French, probably titled "La Première Femme Savante" and most likely focusing on Eve/Eva, in accord with the subject of the later expansion.

instances where text had been modified, until the wove stock's principal and regular use in volume 3. We know that Brontë's publishers had asked her to revise chapter one in February, as is documented in her correspondence.¹³⁰ But, to date, scholars have assumed that Brontë refused to edit the opening of her novel, based on her responses to W. S. Williams and James Taylor of Smith, Elder.¹³¹

The leaves in chapter one do not reflect any apparent change to their inked numbering (see table 4) as we have seen in volume 2 in conjunction with changes in paper stocks. But there is a marked gap where f. 22 should appear that separates the wove leaves of chapter one, which concludes on f. 21, from the laid paper used for chapter two, which begins on f. 23.¹³² This omission carries with it no apparent loss of text, as we learn when collating the manuscript with the first edition—a fact that strongly suggests that Brontë removed f. 22 herself as part of an editorial process.¹³³ Furthermore, f. 21 (the last leaf of chapter one) is written on a recycled leaf whose verso bears the title *Shirley*—another clue that the chapter was revised and recopied only at a later stage, as Brontë did not entirely decide on the title *Shirley* until August 24, 1849—long after she had first sent the manuscript volume 1 to her publisher in February; before that, the novel had been tentatively referred to as *Hollow's Mill*, a title that was ultimately

130. Brontë's correspondence, identified as likely being written on February 20, 1849, reads as follows: "I sincerely thank you both for the candid expression of your objections—what you say with reference to the first chapter shall be duly weighed—At present I feel reluctant to withdraw it—because as I formerly said of the Lowood-part of 'Jane Eyre'—it is true—The curates and their ongoing are merely photographed from the life." *Letters*, 2:181.

131. For example, Jacob Korg writes: "Although Smith and Elder asked her to cut the first chapter, a satiric description of the curates at dinner, Charlotte Brontë refused, arguing that the scene was authentic." See "The Problem of Unity in *Shirley*," *Nineteenth-Century Fiction* 12, no. 2 (1957): 125–36 (126). doi:10.2307/3044150, accessed August 19, 2020. The general view is reflected by Rosengarten and Smith, who do not document or consider any of the bibliographical or codicological evidence presented here, and who write as follows: "Charlotte would not withdraw the offending chapter, telling James Taylor that she could not 'sacrifice truth to the fear of blame'; but she accepted his strictures on 'the bad taste of the opening apostrophe—that I had already condemned in my own mind.'" *Shirley*, xix. Further on, Rosengarten and Smith write: "most of the alterations are slight" in volume 1. Their footnotes and apparatus make no mention of the manuscript evidence that I discuss. In her article, Marin maintains this position: "she did not comply with her publishers' suggestion to drop the first chapter because it might have offended religious readers and it might have destroyed the aesthetic unity of the composition." See Marin, "Charlotte Brontë's Heron Scissors," 24.

132. As I mentioned earlier, the BL conservators inserted a replacement leaf as part of the 1976 rebind—but the leaf is not clearly marked as such.

133. My opinion here is different from that of Smith and Rosengarten, who note: "there is no f. 22, but this seems to be an error: no matter is omitted at this point." See *Shirley*, Clarendon edition, xxiv. While Smith and Rosengarten see this as a numbering error, it is worth observing that Brontë was not prone to making mistakes of this kind. Indeed, there are no other detectable numbering errors of this sort in the entire manuscript. Also, when drawing this conclusion, Smith and Rosengarten did not take into consideration the difference in paper stocks, the differences in leaf numbering made in pencil, or the recycled title page leaf—evidence that clearly suggests a revision was made.

TABLE 4. Leaf numbering in "Levitical" (vol. 1, chap. 1)

BM foliation (E state)	CB pencil (A state)	CB brown ink (1) (B state)	CB red ink (C state)	CB brown ink (2) (D state)
N/A	[Not visible]	1	N/A	N/A
N/A	2	2	N/A	N/A
N/A	3	3	N/A	N/A
N/A	4	4	N/A	N/A
N/A	5	5	N/A	N/A
N/A	6	6	N/A	N/A
N/A	7	7	N/A	N/A
N/A	[8]	8	N/A	N/A
N/A	[9]	9	N/A	N/A
N/A	10	10	N/A	N/A
N/A	13	11	N/A	N/A
N/A	14	12	N/A	N/A
N/A	15	13	N/A	N/A
N/A	16	14	N/A	N/A
N/A	17	15	N/A	N/A
N/A	18	16	N/A	N/A
N/A	19	17	N/A	N/A
N/A	20	18	N/A	N/A
N/A	21	19	N/A	N/A
N/A	22	20	N/A	N/A
N/A	N/A [t.p. verso]	21	N/A	N/A
N/A	N/A	[22]	N/A	N/A
N/A	23	23	N/A	N/A

Paper stock: London Superfine wove, except for (1) leaf [22] (C20 wove [BL conserved]) in B state and (2) leaf 23 (Cream Laid) in A and B states. Leaf 23 is from chapter 2.

rejected by her publishers.¹³⁴ Cumulatively, this evidence suggests that Brontë revisited and revised the first chapter sometime after August 24.

Even so, it is difficult to determine exactly what revisions were made to the chapter. There is significant variation occurring between the "A" pencil numbering sequence and the "B" brown-ink numbering of the leaves, suggesting that Brontë may have made additional changes in the pencil draft that likely served as the updated copy text for the fair-copy manuscript.¹³⁵ As table 4 shows, the penciled leaf numbering skips from "10" to "13"—evidence that suggests that two pages' worth of draft material could have been set aside at the last moment as Brontë edited the chapter. Notably, the penciled numbering ends with f. 22—a detail that leads one to wonder whether Brontë had set out to replace all 22 leaves that may have originally constituted chapter one, before making additional last-minute changes that led her to withdraw ff. 11 and 12, and that necessitated an additional leaf (viz., the unpaginated, recycled leaf bearing the *Shirley* title page on its verso).

The full case becomes somewhat clearer upon reviewing Brontë's correspondence alongside this bibliographical evidence. On February 4, 1849, Brontë mailed the first volume of her manuscript to her publisher with an accompanying letter including the following disclaimer: "The Manuscript has all its errors upon it, not having been read through since copying."¹³⁶ Although W. S. Williams' reply has not survived, in Brontë's correspondence with the firm later that month about their "objections" to the first chapter, she wanted to know in particular their reasons for requesting a change: "I should like you to explain to me more fully the ground of your objections—is it because you think this chapter will render the work liable to severe handling by the press? Is it because knowing as you now do the identity of 'Currer Bell'—this scene strikes you as unfeminine—? Is it because it is intrinsically defective and inferior—? I am afraid the first two reasons would not weigh with me—the last would."¹³⁷

Apparently, Brontë soon afterward received a reply from Williams that, in her words, was "calculated to command careful consideration."¹³⁸ It seems that Williams and Taylor had advised her to "give up Malone and Donne"—two curates who undergo satirical treatment in the published version of the novel, but who may have been subject to even harsher treatment in an earlier version, given that her publishers apparently had told her that the chapter pushed the boundaries of good taste and "artistic treatment." In addition, Brontë's letter sug-

134. On August 21, 1849, Brontë writes to W. S. Williams: "If I remember rightly my Cornhill critics object to 'Hollow's Mill,' nor do I now find it appropriate. It might rather be called 'Fieldhead'—though, I think 'Shirley' would perhaps be the best title: 'Shirley,' I fancy, has turned out the most prominent and peculiar character in the work. Cornhill may decide between 'Fieldhead' and 'Shirley.'" See *Letters*, 2:237. Brontë did refer to the manuscript as "Shirley" in a communication sent on March 1, 1849 to James Taylor; notably, this was after she sent the first draft (and presumably the prior title of "Hollow's Mill") to Smith, Elder on February 4, 1849. See *Letters*, 2:188.

135. The leaf numbering for the first chapter is likely not part of the "A" and "B" sequences described but was introduced during a later pencil-and-ink revision (as with the brown-ink "D" sequence).

136. *Letters*, 2:176.

137. *Letters*, 2:181.

138. *Letters*, 2:185.

gests that Williams and Taylor found the opening scene to be "irrelevant to the book."¹³⁹ Although Brontë did not ultimately cast aside these two characters, she acknowledged in her reply the possible unwelcome repercussions—particularly negative criticism from the "periodical press"—that could result from publishing the chapter as it stood. Then, invoking her identity as the male author Currer Bell, she writes "Currer Bell, without pretending to be David, feels no awe of the unwieldy Anakim," but reassured them that he (Currer Bell) would reasonably accommodate their concerns: "comprehend me rightly, gentlemen—it would grieve him to involve others in blame—any censure that would really injure and annoy his publishers would wound himself—therefore believe that he will not act rashly—trust his discretion."¹⁴⁰ Acknowledging his criticism of the opening apostrophe, she (resuming the voice of "C. Brontë") wanted to move on: "Enough said of a work in embryo—Permit me to request in conclusion that the M.S. may now be returned as soon as convenient."¹⁴¹ Weighing these communications along with the codicological evidence, I believe that Brontë (in this case, operating as Bell) indeed reworked the first chapter in a way that would suit the need to retain Donne and Malone (who appear elsewhere in the novel) while also addressing some of the other concerns that Williams and Taylor had raised. Indeed, there is a letter written by Brontë to her publishers on September 19, 1849 that begins "I have made the alteration—but I have made it to please Cornhill—not the Public nor the critics."¹⁴² Margaret Smith speculated that the "alteration" pertained to the second paragraph in the first chapter; but the evidence offered by the manuscript suggests that the revision was much larger than that.

This revision could also have entailed changes with respect to the novel's introduction and characterization of Michael Hartley, given Brontë's late-stage alterations to volume 2 of the manuscript and also given Hartley's role in the novel's denouement in volume 3. Indeed, a sizable portion—ff. 16 to 20—of chapter one pertains to Hartley. Were the material recopied and revised from the initial, earlier draft, this extended passage would constitute the single prior allusion to Hartley mentioned at the end of volume 3. This hypothesis is supported by the fact that the first chapter is shorter rather than longer in its revision. It is also possible though that Brontë withdrew other, more controversial material from chapter one and filled it out with this extended passage about Hartley; in that case, the inserted material about Hartley in volume 2 would constitute an expansion of what would have been a brief mention about him in that volume. Both scenarios are possible. In either case, a larger pattern and purpose is clear: Brontë made a strategic attempt to unify the novel's action across its three volumes.

This new evidence helps to inform our reading of *Shirley* as a whole. The novel's opening chapter has been widely discussed and debated among critics since the novel's initial release in 1849. Titled "Levitical," the chapter was clearly intended as a critique on both the privileges exacted by junior assistants to senior clergymen,

139. Ibid.

140. *Letters*, 2:186.

141. Ibid.

142. *Letters*, 2:256–57.

as well a satire on their inflated self-importance and grandiose polemical views.¹⁴³ The opening failed to succeed with a number of contemporary readers—this despite Brontë's apparent late intervention at the prior behest of her publishers. George Henry Lewes wrote in his unsigned review of *Shirley* that it was a "mistake" to include the three "offensive, uninstrusive and unamusing" curates featured in the initial chapter of the novel.¹⁴⁴ Over time, the figures have become "infamous" in Brontë criticism, and they continue to be discussed in great detail (viz., Dolin; Perkin; Thormählen).¹⁴⁵ An influential essay written in the mid-twentieth century by Jacob Korg branded the chapter as an "irrelevant" element marring the novel's unity.¹⁴⁶ In keeping with this Lewesian strain of criticism, Tim Dolin has interpreted *Shirley*'s "arbitrariness" as "reinforc[ing] the sense that it resists a logic of historical influence or even causality."¹⁴⁷ He argues that the novel "is plagued with anagnoreses [sic], confessions pleading new beginnings, and reversals of fortune," and notes that "*Shirley* is one of the first English novels to display as structural disturbance the disquieting implications of the modern crowd . . . [a] structural disturbance that was, and still is, perceived to be its formal imperfection."¹⁴⁸ Yet recent critics have welcomed these same qualities as a signal innovation in Brontë's writing. Justine Pizzo argues that the comic nature of *Shirley*'s opening chapter establishes the novel's "episodic structure and seemingly discrete, disunified vignettes that mark its difference from the rest of Brontë's oeuvre."¹⁴⁹

If *Shirley* seems to be episodic in its design, close bibliographical analysis indicates that this was a calculated effect. Brontë carefully considered the risk of retaining her first chapter, as she clearly seems to have modified an earlier, slightly longer version of the chapter (i.e., longer by one leaf) in order to allay at least some of her publishers' concerns, while retaining the characters of Donne, Malone, and Sweeting for her main purpose. The free-wheeling exploits and naughty attitudes of these young, unmarried men starkly contrast with the condition in which the novel's two unmarried heroines find themselves—a marked disparity between the kind of privilege that certain men had (and often abused) and the limitations imposed on women, who were highly restricted in what they could say and do. Although it remains unclear exactly what changes were made to the first chapter, the ultimate fates and fortunes of these curates—who appear elsewhere throughout the novel—are disclosed within the novel's last chapter,

143. See J. Russell Perkin, *Theology and the Victorian Novel* (Montreal & Kingston: McGill-Queen's University Press, 2009), 61.

144. Lewes referred to the curates as he continued: "That they are not inventions, however, we feel persuaded. For nothing but a strong sense of their reality could have seduced the authoress into such a mistake as admitting them at all." Lewes, *Current Bell's 'Shirley'*, 84.

145. Tim Dolin, *Mistress of the House: Women of Property in the Victorian Novel* (Aldershot: Ashgate, 1997); Perkin, *Theology and the Victorian Novel*; and Marianne Thormählen, *The Brontës and Religion* (Cambridge: Cambridge University Press, 1999).

146. Jacob Korg, "The Problem of Unity in *Shirley*," *Nineteenth-Century Fiction* 12, no. 2 (1957): 125–36 (126). doi:10.2307/3044150, accessed August 19, 2020.

147. Tim Dolin, "Fictional Territory and a Woman's Place: Regional and Sexual Difference in *Shirley*," *ELH* 62, no. 1 (1995): 197–215 (205). <http://www.jstor.org/stable/30030266>, accessed October 31, 2020.

148. *Ibid.*

149. Justine Pizzo, "Gendering the Comic Body: Physical Humour in *Shirley*," in *Charlotte Brontë, Embodiment and the Material World*, ed. Justine Pizzo and Eleanor Houghton (Cham, Switzerland: Palgrave Macmillan, 2020), 50.

"The Winding-up." Brontë's inclusio is yet another deliberate bracketing technique that underscores the curates' significance—as well as Michael Hartley's—in the novel's overall structure. As we have seen, it was Brontë's practice to edit and tighten such parallels across the novel's three volumes. Given the material evidence presented here, it is reasonable to suppose that she modified her opening chapter in concert with the composition of the novel's conclusion.

7. THE ROLE OF INTERPRETATION

This article has attempted to call attention to the kinds of rich bibliographical and codicological evidence found in a modern literary manuscript. It has largely focused on demonstrating the utility of correlating variations in the substrates of the manuscript with differences in its numbering. It cannot offer a close analysis of all of the changes made by Brontë, which is better handled in the form of a critical edition. At the same time, it is important to acknowledge that the manuscript contains some significant expansions that entail no apparent changes to its paper stocks.

One notable example, already discussed, is Brontë's revision to her chapter "The First Blue-Stocking"—the "translation" of the French passage that was made in September 1849 per the advice of her publishers. Another even larger expansion preceding that one seems to have gone undetected to date. "Written in the Schoolroom" was copied out by Brontë in the summer of 1849. The chapter, which falls toward the very end of volume 3, describes Louis Moore's proposal to Shirley Keeldar. Ending with f. A851.B851.C858.[D864].E290, the chapter was followed by "The Winding-up." Then, as table 5 shows, a series of ten leaves was inserted as part of stage C of the composition process, as is evident by the changes to the manuscript's red-ink and B-series brown-ink numbering. This new section, demarcated by a double rule of two short pen strokes in the manuscript, begins on the very bottom of f. A851.B851.C858.[D864].E290. Nine leaves later, we find A852.B852.C869.[D875].E301 and its ensuing sequence. What had been a difference in seven leaves between the numbering of states B and C later increased to a difference of 17 leaves.

This newly added section is conveniently framed as an interpolated narrative from Louis Moore's blank book—a narrative device that Brontë uses earlier on in the third volume of the novel in the chapter, "Louis Moore," and later again, at the beginning of "Written in the Schoolroom." Critics such as Lewes found this tactic rather clumsy, as his following critique makes evident:

There, again, there is Louis Moore writing long narratives in his note-book. *What* he writes is often striking; and had the authoress only thought of making him keep a journal, probability would have been sufficiently saved. But, instead of that, she obliges him to sit down in Shirley's room, draw out a note-book, and proceed to write very circumstantially, for our benefit, what everyone feels he would never have *written* at all. And while writing he is so intensely conscious of being *read*, that he says, "I confess it—to this mute page, I may confess it" . . . All that Louis Moore writes might have been told by the authoress, without subterfuge.¹⁵⁰

150. Lewes, "Shirley: a Tale. By Currer Bell, Author of 'Jane Eyre,'" *The Edinburgh Review*, no. 183 (January 1850): 168.

TABLE 5. Leaf numbering in "Written in the Schoolroom" and "The Winding-up" (vol. 3)

BM foliation (E state)	CB pencil (A state)	CB brown ink (1) (B state)	CB red ink (C state)	CB brown ink (2) (D state)
289	850	850	857	[863]
290	851	851	858	[864]
291	852	852	859	[865]
292	853	853	860	[866]
293	854	854	861	[867]
294	855	855	862	[868]
295	856	856	863	[869]
296	857	857	864	[870]
297	858	858	865	[871]
298	859	859	866	[872]
299	860	860	867	[873]
300	861	861	868	[874]
301	852	852 [862]	869	[875]
302	85 [?]	853 [863]	870	[876]
303	854	854 [864]	871	[877]
304	856	855 [865]	872	[878]
305	857	856 [866]	873	[879]
306	858	857 [867]	874	[880]
307	85 [?]	858* [868]	875	[881]
308	860	859 [869]	876	[882]
309	861	860 [870]	877	[883]
310	N/A	N/A	878	[884]
311	[862]	[861][872]	879	[885]

Paper stock: London Superfine wove.

Brontë seems to have anticipated this very criticism. At the outset of this late expansion, her narrator addresses the novel's readers as follows: "Yet again, a passage from the blank book, if you like, reader; if you don't like it, pass it over:—."¹⁵¹ The device, indeed, feels most contrived at this particular point of

151. *Shirley*, Clarendon edition, 713.

the novel—unsurprising, perhaps, given that the entry in question is literally appended to an existing chapter, which was already written in the style of a blank book entry. The later entry made by Louis Moore reports how news of his engagement to *Shirley* is received by her uncle and former guardian, Mr. Sympson—a scene entailing some rather charged language, owing to Mr. Sympson's objection to having his niece marry her former tutor. Perhaps the narrative device of the blank book was especially helpful in this instance: Moore writes that Mr. Sympson "uttered words with which this page shall never be polluted."¹⁵² Yet, without a doubt, the device of Moore's entries in his "blank book" also readily allowed Brontë to adjust and adapt this portion of her narrative with comparative ease when she was pressed for time. Indeed, as we have already seen, *Shirley* contains a number of interpolated texts that served as a convenient node of access for expansion and revision. This example and *Shirley*'s essay on Eva are two of six instances of such texts that were altered in a way that entailed partial-leaf excisions or the insertions of new leaves.

One final and telling example of a change to an interpolated text can be found in the first volume of the novel within the chapter "Coriolanus," which bears a partial-leaf excision and repair to f. A126.B126. The following leaf features two stanzas of André Chénier's poem "La jeune captive," which Caroline Helstone recites to her cousin, Robert Moore, with whom she is secretly in love. These stanzas clearly offer a coded commentary on her private feelings toward her cousin: "Mon beau voyage encore est si loin de sa fin! | . . . | Un instant seulement mes lèvres ont pressé | La coupe en mes mains encore pleine"; "The voyage of life is but begun for me | . . . | My lips have hardly touched the cup as yet | Still brimming in my hand."

Brontë cut out about five or six lines preceding the two stanzas, pasting into their place a slip of paper with a commentary on Caroline's taste in poetry. The new text, fashioned as a footnote, reads:

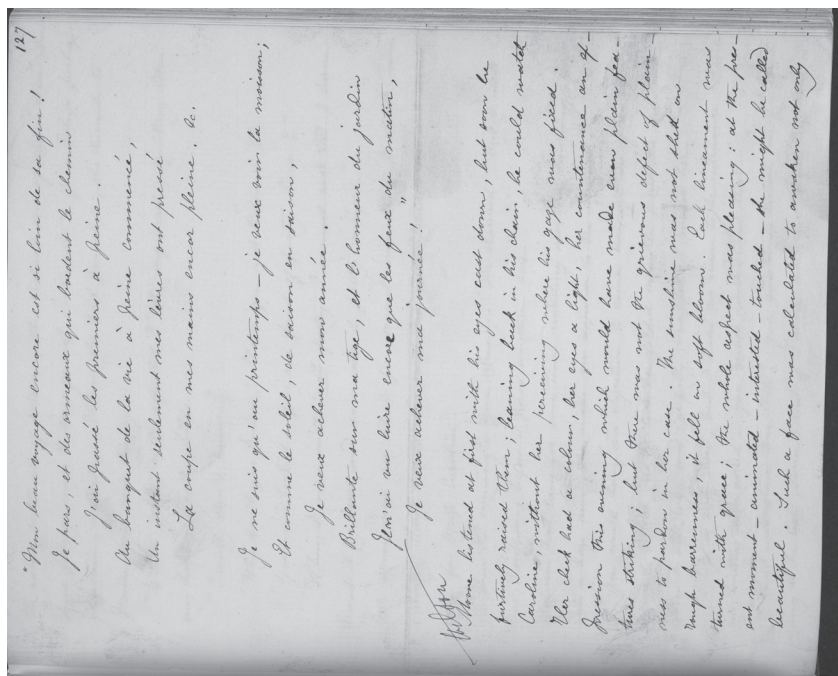
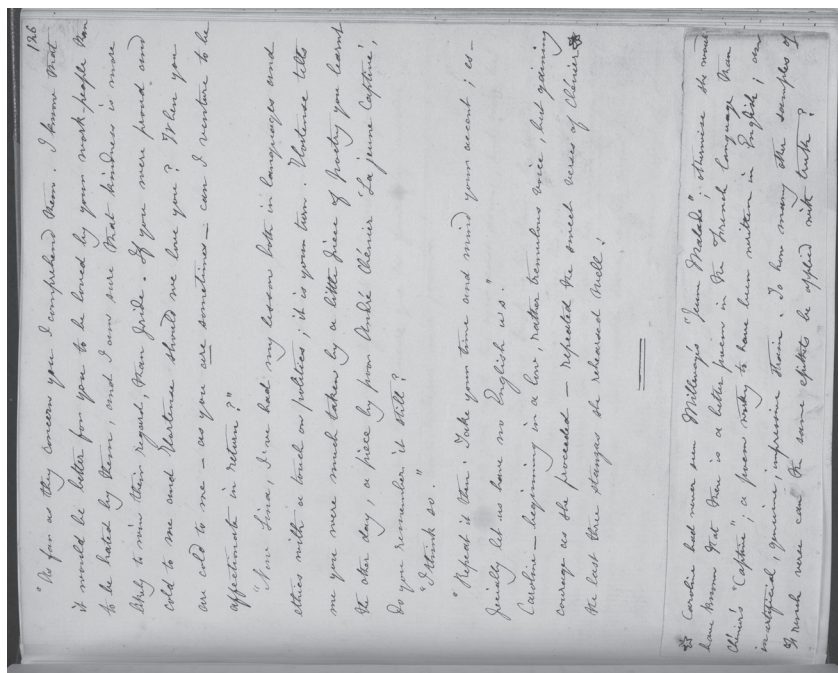
† Caroline had never seen Millevoe's "Jeune Malade," otherwise she would have known that there is a better poem in the French language than Chénier's "Captive;" a poem worthy to have been written in English,—an inartificial, genuine, impressive strain. To how many other samples of French verse can the same epithets be applied with truth?

Although it is unclear exactly what text was excised from f. A126.B126, one distinct possibility is that the leaf bore the poem's preceding stanza, which runs approximately the same length as the prior two. The case for a third stanza having been present is further supported in the novel by the narrator's reference to the "last three stanzas" that Caroline "rehearsed well."¹⁵³ The stanza that was probably present in the manuscript and later removed would have likely read as follows:

Est-ce à moi de mourir? Tranquille je m'endors,
Et tranquille je veille; et ma veille aux remords
Ni mon sommeil ne sont en proie.
Ma bienvenue au jour me rit dans tous les yeux;

152. *Shirley*, Clarendon edition, 716.

153. *Shirley*, Clarendon edition, 106.



FIGURES 7 AND 8. Ff. A126.B126 and A127.B127. Note the repair and new text appended to the lower portion of f. A126.B126. © British Library Board, ff. 126 and 127, Add MS 43477.

Sur des fronts abattus, mon aspect dans ces lieux
Ranime presque de la joie.¹⁵⁴

Why would these lines have been excised and replaced with this new paratextual device? It seems that this scene required especially careful handling. Brontë may have initially included this stanza to foreshadow Caroline's near-death experience, resulting from her own unrequited love for Moore: "Est-ce à moi de mourir?"; "Is it my lot to die?" Yet to a discerning nineteenth-century reader, the inclusion of such lines could have been interpreted as an unseemly attempt by Caroline to advance herself in the estimation of Robert Moore: "Ma bienvenue au jour me rit dans tous les yeux; | Sur des fronts abattus, mon aspect dans ces lieux | Ranime presque de la joie"; "My welcome shines from every morning face, | And to these downcast souls my presence in this place | Almost restores their joy." Had Brontë left the stanza in the manuscript, Caroline could have been seen to be insinuating that she, like the sun, serves a central role in the lives of the Moores—that without her, their lives would be dreary and downcast. If Brontë indeed removed this particular stanza, it would have helped to counteract or at least to soften such criticism. (Indeed, Mrs. Yorke openly accuses Caroline of this very kind of coy behavior later in the novel.) Brontë's footnote thus serves as a rhetorical decoy—an intellectualized, defensive strategy recasting the focus of this romantic scene into an analysis of French poetry—and a modification calculated to detract attention from the very real implication that Caroline Helstone is, in fact, courting Robert Moore. Although these findings must remain open to further interpretation, they are meant to offer a sense of how bibliography can draw together two forms of analysis—one based in codicology, the other in close reading—in a way that is still very much grounded in the manuscript as artifact.

More generally, this kind of close reading, which entails text and object alike, provides a means for revisiting the kinds of scholarly narratives that have formed around the historical practices of writers—in this case, an author whose identity as a woman has raised, for some critics, questions about censure, silence, and erasure with respect to her writing practice. Brontë was undoubtedly concerned with matters of gender, as is evident throughout her novels, as well as in her use of a male pseudonym that extended into her correspondence, where we find marked opinions held by "Currer Bell." As communicated to her publishers, she did not want to be restricted to what would be conceived as "feminine" language. Even so, as a close analysis of the manuscript of *Shirley* shows, during this time her work as a writer was shaped and even supplanted by her role as a caregiver—a tension between work and home that few male authors of Currer Bell's stature would have experienced, at least to anything approaching the same degree.

154. C. D. Warner et al. translation via Bartleby: <https://www.bartleby.com/library/poem/1315.html>, accessed December 20, 2020:

Is it my lot to die? In peace I lay me down,
In peace awake again, a peace nor care doth drown,
Nor fell remorse destroy.
My welcome shines from every morning face,
And to these downcast souls my presence in this place
Almost restores their joy.

By turning our attention to the materials and mechanics of writing processes as well as the role of women's labor, we can gain clearer insight into the historical practices and domestic duties that marked women's writing. Although material surfaces are silent, laid or wove, embossed or watermarked, excised or intact, they can speak to activities otherwise undocumented in the historical record. By learning how to discern the changes introduced by Brontë amid those made by the hands of many others—printers, publishers, collectors, bookbinders, curators, and conservators—we find the story of a rising woman author who prioritized the care of her family over the expectations of her publishers and readers. Having lived through a global pandemic, many of us are now more attuned to the caregiving duties required of those coping with grave illness. It is helpful, I think, to understand Brontë's break from working on the manuscript as a decision necessitated by this more urgent charge.

And yet we also see another choice at work at a later stage of composition: a strategic process of revision that drew together plot points across the book's three volumes—deliberate changes that, when introduced, drew together the narrative threads of Brontë's novel. By studying the manuscript slowly, carefully, and methodically using the techniques afforded by bibliography, these two distinct stages emerge from among the manuscript's complex layers of composition to tell a more nuanced story of how Charlotte Brontë's work as a writer intersected with her duties as both a daughter and sister. Sometimes slowing down—as Brontë herself was forced to—allows us to revisit our own critical assumptions with fresh eyes and a clearer sense of purpose. Where her work as a writer left legible traces, her labor as a caregiver created subtle absences barely detectable, but still discernable, in the leaves she left behind.